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2 Timothy

2 Timothy 1:1

Section 1:1–2: Paul sent greetings to Timothy

The people who wrote letters during the time when Paul lived began the letters that they wrote in a certain way. The author of a letter wrote his name first, and then he wrote the name of the person to whom he was writing the letter. After that, he wrote a greeting to the person or group to whom he was writing.

1:1a

Paul, an apostle of Christ Jesus by the will of God,

- ¶ This letter is from me, Paul. God wanted/chose me to be an apostle of Christ Jesus
- ¶ I am Paul. I am writing this letter to you. God wanted/chose to send me to tell people the message about Christ Jesus.

Paul, an apostle of Christ Jesus: Paul began this letter to Timothy by stating his own name first. Then he said something about himself. In some languages, it is not natural or possible for a person to talk about himself using the third person. You may not be able to say, “This letter is from Paul, an apostle of Christ Jesus.” If this is the case in your language, you can say something like:

This letter is from me, Paul. I am an apostle of Christ Jesus.

I, Paul, am writing this letter. I am an apostle of Christ Jesus.

an apostle of Christ Jesus: The word apostle means “a person whom someone has sent to do a specific job on behalf of that sender.” In 1:1, Paul said that Christ Jesus personally chose and sent him to be his ambassador or messenger of the gospel to other people. Paul was to represent Christ Jesus to others. See apostle in the Glossary.

Christ Jesus: The word Christ is used two ways in the New Testament. In the Gospels, Christ is a title for Jesus. It means “the anointed one.” But later when Paul and the other apostles and disciples wrote the letters to individuals and churches, the word Christ was used as another name for Jesus rather than as a title.

Notice that in this verse Paul referred to Jesus as Christ Jesus instead of “Jesus Christ.” The names Christ Jesus and “Jesus Christ” mean the same thing.

In most English translations and other national language translations, “Jesus Christ” and “Christ Jesus” are translated literally and in the same order as they occur in the Greek manuscripts. It is recommended that you do the same thing. However, if you think that the people who will be reading your translation might be confused when they see two different word orders of the names, you may decide to translate Christ Jesus as “Jesus Christ,” which is the more familiar word order. See also Christ in the Glossary.

by the will of God: The phrase by the will of God means that “God wanted Paul to be an apostle.” Paul himself did not decide to become an apostle. Another way of describing the will of God is to say that “God choose Paul to be an apostle.”

1:1b

according to the promise of life

- so that I might preach the message that God has promised to give eternal life
- He sent me so that I might tell people that God has promised us^(incl) that we^(incl)/people may live forever with him/God

according to: The BSB translates the Greek preposition kata as according to. This word introduces God’s purpose for calling Paul to be an apostle. Some ways to translate this idea are:

- Use a prepositional phrase as the BSB has done.

^{1a}Paul, an apostle of Christ Jesus by the will of God, ^{1b}according to the promise of life that is in Christ Jesus

- Use a conjunction.

^{1a}God chose me to be an apostle ^{1b}in order to make known the promise of life that is in Christ Jesus

- Use a verb, as GNT has done.

^{1a}God chose me to be an apostle ^{1b}and sent me to proclaim the promise of life...

the promise of life: In the Greek text, the word that the BSB translates as life here refers to spiritual and eternal life, not physical life. God appointed Paul and sent him to many different places to preach the gospel. Paul told the people in these places that God had promised to give them eternal life if they would trust in the Lord Jesus Christ.

1:1c**in Christ Jesus,**

- that comes from Christ Jesus.
- because Christ Jesus makes it possible.
- God promised to give this eternal life to those who believe in Christ Jesus.

in Christ Jesus: The phrase “in Christ Jesus” or “in Christ” occurs many times in Paul’s letters. The BSB, NIV, and RSV always translate it literally. GNT usually translates it as “in union with Christ.” Because this phrase can mean different things in different contexts, you should always decide the best way to translate it in each context. In this verse, the context is life in Christ Jesus. Some ways of translating the entire phrase are:

God has promised life that has its source in Christ Jesus

God has promised life that is possible because of what Christ Jesus has done

2 Timothy 1:2**Section 1:1–2: Paul sent greetings to Timothy**

The people who wrote letters during the time when Paul lived began the letters that they wrote in a certain way. The author of a letter wrote his name first, and then he wrote the name of the person to whom he was writing the letter. After that, he wrote a greeting to the person or group to whom he was writing.

1:2a**To Timothy,**

- I am writing this letter to you, Timothy.

To Timothy: Timothy was the name of the person to whom Paul wrote this letter. In some languages it is necessary to say: “I am writing to you, Timothy....”

1:2b**my beloved child:**

- You are like a dear son to me.
- I love you as much as I would love my own son.

my beloved child: Timothy was not Paul’s child in the physical sense of that word. But Paul referred to Timothy several times as his “child.” This is perhaps because Paul had been responsible for Timothy’s spiritual conversion. If the people reading your translation only understand this phrase literally, you may want to say something like:

you are like a beloved child to me

it is as if you are my dear son

1:2c**Grace, mercy, and peace from God the Father and Christ Jesus our Lord.**

- I pray that God our^(incl) Father and Christ Jesus our^(incl) Lord will be kind to you, treat you with compassion, and grant you inner peace.

Grace, mercy, and peace from God the Father and Christ Jesus our Lord:

This phrase was a common way for Christians to greet each other during the time when Paul lived. It is a sort of prayer or blessing. Paul was asking God to bless Timothy. You may need to begin this blessing with a verb clause such as “I pray that God will give you...” or “I ask God to give you....”

Grace: The authors of the New Testament letters often used the word Grace in their greetings at the beginning of their letters. It is used to express their desire that God would bless the people who received the letter or to wish them well. Grace means that God favors people or that he is kind to people even though they do not deserve it. See grace in the Glossary, Meaning 1.

mercy: The Greek word that English versions translate as mercy means that God treats us kindly or with compassion, or that he pities us. See mercy in the Glossary, Meaning 1.

peace: The Greek word that is translated peace here refers to the satisfaction we have in our innermost beings because we are in a harmonious relationship with God. This peaceful relationship is possible because he has forgiven our sins, and he causes us to live without having anxiety and fear. In this verse, peace is not referring to a person being at peace with other people.

God the Father: You may need to translate this phrase as “God our (incl) Father” if that is the natural way to say this phrase in your language.

General Comment on 1:2c

Your language may usually require that you translate each of these nouns with a clause, rather than a single word. However, when translating greetings, you may want to use something shorter. In 1:2c, Paul was giving Timothy greetings, not teaching him about grace, mercy, and peace. Therefore it may not be necessary to include all the elements that are normally associated with these key terms.

2 Timothy 1:3

Section 1:3–18: Paul encouraged Timothy to continue doing the work that God gave him to do

1:3a

I thank God, whom I serve

- ¶ I am thankful to God. He is the one whom I serve/ worship
- ¶ I thank God for you. I worship him

I serve: The word serve here refers to serving or working for God in a religious way. It might be better to use a word that means “worship.” For example, the REB says:

I worship with a clear conscience.

1:3b

with a clear conscience as did my forefathers,

- even as my ancestors served/worshiped him. I serve/ worship him with a clear conscience.
- and I know that God knows/sees that I have not done anything wrong. He is the God whom my ancestors served/worshiped also.

with a clear conscience: The phrase with a clear conscience can be understood as referring:

1. only to Paul. “I serve God as my ancestors did. I serve him with a clear conscience.”
2. to both Paul and his forefathers. “I serve God with a clear conscience. My ancestors also served God with a clear conscience.”

In most English translations, it is unclear whether the phrase with a clear conscience refers only to Paul or to both Paul and his forefathers. However, if possible in your language, translate in a way that people will understand the first interpretation. One reason for choosing interpretation (1) is that in this verse Paul was writing about his personal claim that he was an apostle. He was not necessarily claiming that his ancestors also had clear consciences.

a clear conscience: A person’s conscience is the part of a person that helps him know what is right and what is wrong to think or do. A conscience causes a person to feel ashamed or guilty if he does wrong, and makes him feel good when he does what is right.

Paul was implying that, although he was in prison, he was not there because he had committed a crime. On the contrary, he had been put in prison because he was trying to do what would please God. Paul was convinced that he had not done anything wrong. He did not feel guilty, so his conscience was clear.

forefathers: Another word for forefathers is “ancestors.” The word forefathers refers to a person’s relatives who were born before his parents and probably even before his grandparents.

1:3c

as I constantly remember you night and day in my prayers.

- I thank God while I constantly pray for you day and night.
- Whether it is at night or during the day, I always remember to pray for you.

as I constantly remember you night and day in my prayers: This is a way of saying that Paul prayed very frequently and when he prayed, he always prayed for Timothy.

constantly: The Greek word that most English versions translate as constantly is emphasized in the Greek text. In the Display, this emphasis is shown by putting the word constantly before the verb “pray.”

night and day: Scholars differ as to whether the phrase night and day is connected to 1:3 or 1:4.

1. Most English versions understand this phrase to belong to I constantly remember you... in my prayers in 1:3. For example, the NLT says:

Night and day I constantly remember you in my prayers. See also BSB, NIV, GNT, NRSV, NET, NASB, REB, NJB, KJV, GW, CEV.

1. A few translations have punctuated the sentence in such a way that this phrase belongs with “I long to see you” at the beginning of 1:4. For example, the RSV says:

⁴As I remember your tears, I long night and day to see you, See also JBP.

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1) as do the majority of translations.

2 Timothy 1:4

Section 1:3–18: Paul encouraged Timothy to continue doing the work that God gave him to do

1:4a

Recalling your tears,

- I remember that when you and I parted, you were very sad and you wept.

Recalling your tears: Paul mentioned that Timothy wept. This probably refers to the last time that they were together just before Paul went to prison.

1:4b

I long to see you

- So, I very much want to see you again,

I long to see you: To long to see someone means “to strongly desire to see” that person. Paul was lonely in prison and missed Timothy. He hoped that Timothy could come to Rome and visit him.

1:4c

so that I may be filled with joy.

- so that I may have great/much joy.

so that I may be filled with joy: Paul would be very happy when Timothy came to see him. In some languages, people do not use the verb phrase be filled with to describe a person’s feelings. If this is the case in your language, you could translate be filled with as: “I know that you will cause me to be very happy.”

joy: The word joy is emphasized in the Greek text. This emphasis is shown in the Display by using the words “great/much” before joy, or “very” before “happy.”

2 Timothy 1:5

Section 1:3–18: Paul encouraged Timothy to continue doing the work that God gave him to do

1:5a

I am reminded of your sincere faith,

- I remember/recall that you genuinely/truly believe in Christ Jesus.

I am reminded: The Greek clause that the BSB translates as I am reminded is literally “taking remembrance.” The verb is not passive, as the BSB translation implies, but active. The verb here can be translated as “I remember” (see GNT, NJB, CEV, NCV), or “I recall” (see NET).

sincere faith: In your language it may be clearer to say, “you truly believed in Christ Jesus.” This same phrase sincere faith is found in 1 Timothy 1:5. See also faith in the Glossary, Meaning 1.

1:5b

which first dwelt in your grandmother Lois and your mother Eunice,

- Your grandmother Lois and your mother Eunice believed in him before you did,

which first dwelt in your grandmother Lois and your mother Eunice: Paul wrote here about “faith” as if it

were a person. When Paul used the phrase first dwelt, he meant that Timothy’s grandmother and mother “had faith” in Jesus Christ before Timothy did.

In some languages it is natural to say that Timothy’s mother and grandmother “had faith” in Jesus Christ. (GNT is an example of this.) But if this is not natural in your language, then you may need to replace the noun “faith” with the verb “believe.” Then you would state who believed (that is, “your grandmother Lois and your mother Eunice believed”). You may also need to add the implied information that they believed “in Jesus Christ.”

grandmother: Here the term grandmother refers to “the mother of Timothy’s mother.”

1:5c

and I am convinced is in you as well.

- and I am convinced/sure that you now believe in him also.

I am convinced: The Greek word that the BSB translates as convinced also means “persuaded.” Paul saw evidence that Timothy truly believed in Jesus because of what Timothy had learned from his mother and his grandmother, and also because Paul had seen that Timothy behaved as a true follower of Christ. These things made Paul sure/certain that Timothy truly believed in Jesus.

is in you as well: Here, the clause in you as well is similar to what Paul said concerning Timothy’s mother and grandmother in 1:5b. In many languages it is more straightforward to translate this with a clause similar to:

you also believe in Jesus now

2 Timothy 1:6

Section 1:3–18: Paul encouraged Timothy to continue doing the work that God gave him to do

1:6a

For this reason I remind you to fan into flame the gift of God,

- That is why I remind you to rekindle/revive the spiritual gift that God gave to you
- Since you genuinely believe, that is why I remind you to use energetically the special ability that God gave to you

For this reason: The phrase For this reason refers to Timothy’s sincere faith in Christ (1:5a). One way to translate For this reason is to make the reason explicit by saying:

Since you genuinely believe

to fan into flame: Here Paul compared Timothy's gift to a fire. The clause fan into flame is the translation of one Greek word. There are two ways to interpret this word:

1. Paul was concerned that Timothy had not been using his gift to his fullest capacity. Therefore he challenged Timothy to "fan into flame" or "rekindle" his use of the gift. For example, the NLT says:

This is why I remind you to fan into flames the spiritual gift God gave you See also BSB, NIV, RSV, NASB, NET, REB, NJB, GW, JBP.

1. Paul was simply encouraging Timothy to continue to use his gift. He was not implying that Timothy had not been using his gift. For example, the NCV says:

This is why I remind you to keep using the gift God gave you See also GNT and CEV.

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1).

This interpretation uses this Greek word in its literal sense, that is, "rekindle" or "light again." This implies that Timothy's gift was like a fire that had almost gone out or died and needed to be revived to a useful state. One can rekindle a fire by fanning it or by stirring up the coals.

the gift of God: This spiritual gift was a special ability that God gave Timothy. It enabled him to serve God and minister to other believers in Ephesus. Several verses in 2 Timothy imply that the gift that God had given to Timothy was the ability to serve as a leader (see 4:2 and 4:5).

General Comment on 1:6a

When the word gift is used with the word "rekindle," the two become a vivid figure of speech. By using this figure of speech, Paul meant that Timothy should reactivate his spiritual gift. This was the gift that the Holy Spirit had given him and that he was to use for God's service.

You have several options for translating the figure of speech fan into flame the gift of God.

- Maintain the figure of speech, if possible.
- Use a figure of speech that occurs in your language and means something like "to start doing something energetically again."

- Replace the figure of speech with the direct meaning and translate it "restore/reactivate/revive the gift of God."

1:6b

which is in you through the laying on of my hands.

- when I laid/put my hands on your head.
- Remember that you received that gift when I laid my hands on you.

which is in you through the laying on of my hands:

Some time previously, Paul had put his hands on Timothy (probably on his head). Then he prayed that God would give him a special ability to minister to the believers in the Ephesian church. Paul implied that Timothy received that gift/ability at that time. (Perhaps Paul refers here to the time he mentioned in 1 Timothy 4:14 when the elders prayed for Timothy, but in this verse he mentions only that he laid his hands on Timothy.)

2 Timothy 1:7

Section 1:3–18: Paul encouraged Timothy to continue doing the work that God gave him to do

1:7a

For God has not given us a spirit of fear,

- For God did not give a timid/fearful nature to us^(incl).
- God did not make us afraid to serve him.

For: The conjunction For connects this verse to 1:6. For introduces the reason why Timothy should rekindle his gift.

us: Notice that in this verse, Paul changed his discourse from addressing Timothy as "you" in 1:6 to using the word us. In this declaration, Paul was speaking of at least Timothy and himself. It is also possible that he was including all Christians.

a spirit of fear: There are two ways to interpret the word spirit here:

1. It means our human spirit/nature. For example:

God did not give us a spirit that makes us afraid.... (NCV) (BSB, NIV, RSV, NASB, REB, NJB, KJV, NCV, GW, NLT)

1. It means the Holy Spirit. For example:

God's Spirit doesn't make cowards out of us. (CEV) (GNT, NET, CEV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1) and the majority of Bible scholars.

fear: In this context fear means “timidity.” It describes a person who fears doing something that is his duty to do, and so he refuses to do it or avoids doing it. In this context, it probably means that Timothy had been afraid to do some of the tasks that God had told him to do and had given him a special ability to do.

1:7b but of power,

- On the contrary, God gives us spiritual power,
- Instead, God enables us to serve him with strength,

but: The Greek conjunction *alla*, which means but, indicates a strong contrast between 1:7a and 1:7b. Some other ways to indicate this strong contrast are “instead” or “on the contrary.”

a spirit of power: As was explained in 1:7a, Paul was talking about the human spirit/nature. The human, fearful spirit contrasts greatly with the power that God gives. It is not physical power, but spiritual power.

1:7c love,

- he causes/enables us to love people,

love: Here Paul is primarily talking about love for other people.

1:7d and self-control.

- and he causes/enables us to control ourselves.
- and he causes/enables us to control how we think and behave.

and self-control: A person who has self-control has good judgment and practices restraint in what he (or she) says and does. He is able to control the way he thinks or behaves.

2 Timothy 1:8

Section 1:3–18: Paul encouraged Timothy to continue doing the work that God gave him to do

Paragraph 1:8–12

This is the first paragraph in which Paul gave Timothy some specific examples/instructions about how he should use his gift mentioned in 1:6a. In this paragraph Paul told Timothy not to be ashamed of the gospel, but to be prepared to suffer for being a follower of Christ.

1:8a So do not be ashamed of the testimony of our Lord,

- ¶ So do not be ashamed/embarrassed to tell people about our^(incl) Lord Jesus Christ.

So: The Greek conjunction *oun*, which the BSB translates as So, connects 1:7 and 1:8. This is a grounds (1:7)—exhortation (1:8)—relationship. Another way to show this is:

^{1:7} Since God did not give us a spirit of fear...

^{1:8} therefore do not be ashamed/afraid to testify about our Lord.

do not be ashamed of the testimony of our Lord:

Paul implied here that, because Timothy was timid or fearful, he might be reluctant to tell other people the good news about Jesus Christ. Therefore, Paul told him to speak boldly about Jesus.

of the testimony: Another way to say this is “to witness,” “to share,” or “to tell.”

1:8b or of me, His prisoner.

- Also, do not be ashamed of me, a prisoner because of the Lord.
- Also, do not be embarrassed that you know me. I am in prison because I have served the/our^(incl) Lord.

or of me, His prisoner: Apparently Paul thought that Timothy might be ashamed to admit that he knew Paul because Paul was in prison. Prisoners were normally people who had committed crimes, so most people were ashamed of a friend or relative who was in prison.

His prisoner: The word His refers to Christ. Paul meant that the Roman authorities had put him in prison because he was serving Christ. Be careful that when you translate His prisoner that your translation does not imply that Christ was keeping Paul in prison. Here is one way to translate this:

Do not be ashamed of being my friend, although I am a prisoner because I serve Christ.

1:8c Instead, join me in suffering for the gospel by the power of God.

- Rather, join me in suffering for the sake of the gospel. God will give you the power to do it.
- Instead, with the power/strength that God gives you, suffer with me on behalf of the good news which we tell people.

Instead: The Greek conjunction *alla*, which the BSB translates as Instead, indicates a strong contrast between 1:8a–b and 1:8c. Some other ways to show this contrast are “Rather” or But.”

join me in suffering: This is the translation of one Greek verb. It means “to suffer like someone else has suffered” or “to share another person’s hardships.”

Paul knew that he would continue to suffer because he preached to people about Jesus Christ. So he urged Timothy to follow his example, to be willing to suffer for Christ, and to endure the evil things that people would do to him because he was preaching this good news.

for the gospel: Some others ways to say this phrase are:

for the sake of the gospel

on behalf of the gospel

for telling people the gospel

gospel: The Greek word that the BSB translates as gospel literally means “good news.” However, in the New Testament the word gospel does not mean just any kind of good news. It specifically means “the good news that God has made a way to save sinful human beings through Jesus.”

Some ways to translate gospel are:

good news

good message

God’s message

God’s good news

message from God

message of/about Jesus

See also the word gospel in the Glossary.

by the power of God: The phrase by the power of God indicates how Timothy could endure suffering for preaching the gospel. He could endure suffering “through” or “by means of” the power that God would give him. God had given Paul strength to endure suffering, and God would also give Timothy strength to endure suffering.

In some languages, it may be best to put this phrase by the power of God before the phrase about suffering. This is what the NET, NLT, and CEV do. The NLT has:

With the strength God gives you, be ready to suffer with me for the proclamation of the good news.

2 Timothy 1:9

Section 1:3–18: Paul encouraged Timothy to continue doing the work that God gave him to do

Paragraph 1:8–12

This is the first paragraph in which Paul gave Timothy some specific examples/instructions about how he should use his gift mentioned in 1:6a. In this paragraph Paul told Timothy not to be ashamed of the gospel, but to be prepared to suffer for being a follower of Christ.

1:9–11

In 1:9–11 Paul reviewed the chief points of the gospel. He talked about several distinct thoughts here. It will probably be necessary for you to put these thoughts in separate sentences. GNT begins a new sentence at 1:9, with God as the subject of the verb.

1:9a

He has saved us

- God has saved us from eternal death

He has saved us: God has saved us from eternal death. See save in the Glossary.

1:9b

and called us to a holy calling,

- and has called/invited us to live a holy life.
- and has called us to be holy.

and called us to a holy calling: A literal translation of this clause is: “and having called us with/to a holy calling.” Because the Greek preposition in this clause may be translated as either “with” or “to,” there are two ways to interpret this part of the verse:

1. God called us “to a holy calling.” According to this interpretation, the term “holy calling” refers to what God called us to. For example, GW says:

God saved us and called us to be holy.... See also BSB, NIV, GNT, REB, NJB, NLT, JBP, NLT, CEV, JBP, NCV.

1. God called us “with/by-means-of a holy calling.” According to this interpretation, the term “holy calling” is a description of the way that God called us. For example the NET says:

He is the one who saved us and called us with a holy calling.... See also RSV, NASB, KJV.

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). There are several translation possibilities for this interpretation. These are discussed below.

called: The word called is used in a special sense here. It means “summoned” or “chosen” (NLT, CEV), or “invited.” Do not use a word that only refers to someone “calling loudly.”

a holy calling: Following interpretation (1) above, you can translate holy calling as:

God called us to live a holy life.

God called us to be his holy people.

God called us to be holy.

See also holy in the Glossary, Meaning 1.

1:9c

not because of our works,

- He called/chose us not because we have done good deeds/works,
- He did not call us because we had done anything good to deserve it.
- He chose us, even though we have not done anything righteous.

not because of our works: This clause refers back to the two verbs in 1:9a–b. That is, “He (God) saved us and called/chose us (incl).” He did all of this for us even though we had not done anything to deserve it.

our works: This refers to the acts or deeds that we have done, and the way we have behaved.

1:9d

but by His own purpose and by the grace

- but because of his own plan to choose us and show his kindness to us.
- Instead, he called us because he himself had planned to do it and because he wanted to be kind to us in this manner.

but by His own purpose and by the grace: This phrase explains the reason for which God saved us and chose us to be his holy people. As in 1:9c, the phrase that follows by depends on the verbs that are in 1:9a–b. Therefore, in 1:9a–d Paul was saying that God saved us and called us because he planned to do these things.

purpose and by the grace: The words purpose and grace are abstract nouns. It may be necessary in your language to use verbs rather than nouns to express these concepts. In this context, purpose refers to what God planned to do and grace means that God favors people or is kind to people even though they do not deserve it. See grace in the Glossary, Meaning 2.

General Comment on 1:9a–d

In some languages it may be more natural to break 1:9a–d into several sentences and/or to reverse the order of 1:9c and 1:9d as follows:

God saved us and called us to live a holy life. He did this because of his own purpose and grace. He did not do this because we have done anything to deserve it.

1:9e

He granted us in Christ Jesus before time began.

- God had graciously/kindly planned to send Christ Jesus into the world for our sakes/benefit even before he made the world.
- Before the world existed, God planned to show us his kindness by sending Christ Jesus into the world to die for us.

the grace He granted us: The clause the grace He granted us means “God was kind to us even though we did not deserve it.” See grace in the Glossary, Meaning 2.

in Christ Jesus: This phrase tells how God was kind to us. He planned to save us from eternal death by means of Jesus Christ dying for us on the cross.

before time began: God planned this long ago. He planned it even before he made the world or created any human being.

2 Timothy 1:10

Section 1:3–18: Paul encouraged Timothy to continue doing the work that God gave him to do

Paragraph 1:8–12

This is the first paragraph in which Paul gave Timothy some specific examples/instructions about how he should use his gift mentioned in 1:6a. In this paragraph Paul told Timothy not to be ashamed of the gospel, but to be prepared to suffer for being a follower of Christ.

1:10a

And now He has revealed this grace

- And now God has shown/revealed to us this grace/kindness.

- And now we see/know about God's kindness
- We now know about his kindness

And now He has revealed this grace: Scholars have different opinions about the way the clause now He has revealed relates to “before time began” in 1:9e. The Greek is ambiguous. There are two points of view about how these two periods of time relate to each other.

1. Some scholars say that the two clauses should be connected with an and. They believe that 1:10a expresses the next step in God's plan of grace. For example, the NLT says:

And now he has made all of this plain to us.... See also BSB, RSV, REB, LSA.

1. Other scholars say that the two clauses should be connected with a but. They believe that 1:10a expresses a contrast in time with 1:9e. For example, the NCV says:

but it is now shown to us... See also NIV, GNT, NET, NASB, KJV, NJB.

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). However, interpretation (2) also has much support. If the major language version in your area follows interpretation (2), you may want to follow interpretation (2) instead.

this grace: Grace continues to be the subject in 1:10a. God has revealed/shown to us his grace through the life, death, and resurrection of Jesus Christ.

1:10b
through the appearing of our Savior, Christ Jesus,

- It is through/by Christ Jesus, our^(incl) Savior, who appeared to us.
- because Christ Jesus, who saved us,^(incl) came to earth.

through the appearing of our Savior, Christ Jesus: The phrase the appearing of our Savior refers to all that Jesus did while he lived on the earth. It includes Jesus' death and rising again.

our Savior, Christ Jesus: This is the only time in the New Testament Greek text that these three names occur in this order. In other places in the New Testament text, the order of this phrase is always “(our) Savior Jesus Christ.” It is recommended that you retain the same order for Christ Jesus here as you used in 1:1a.

Savior: Savior here means “one who saves/rescues someone from spiritual and eternal danger.” See Savior in the Glossary, Meaning 3.

1:10c
who has abolished death

- He destroyed/ended/defeated the power of death,
- Jesus destroyed/ended the power of all things that would harm a person after he dies,

who has abolished death: Paul spoke of death as something that Christ abolished/destroyed/defeated. Not all languages speak about death this way. You need to translate this to show that the effects of death are ended. Physically, the bodies of Christians will be raised to life when Christ returns. Spiritually, Christians do not die. They go to be with Christ (Philippians 1:23).

Another way to say this is:

He has ended the power of death (GNT).

1:10d
and illuminated the way to life and immortality through the gospel,

- and he showed us^(incl) through the good news that there is a way for us^(incl) to live forever.
- and he used the good news to show/reveal everlasting life to us.

and illuminated the way to life and immortality through the gospel: “Our Savior, Christ Jesus” (1:10b) continues to be the subject here. Because of the presence of the Greek word men in v.10c, consultants should check that v.10d has received at least as much prominence as 10c, preferably more.

illuminated the way: The phrase that the BSB translates as illuminated the way is a metaphor that means “to show” or “to reveal.” Christ has allowed us to “see/know/experience” life and immortality.

life and immortality: In this phrase the word immortality describes life. Together these two terms mean “a (spiritual) life that lasts forever.” Two possible ways to translate this are:

immortal life (GNT)

everlasting life (NLT)

through the gospel: The gospel message (or good news) was the means that Christ (and his followers)

used to tell human beings that he had given them everlasting life.

gospel: See gospel in the Glossary and in the notes at 1:8c.

2 Timothy 1:11

Section 1:3–18: Paul encouraged Timothy to continue doing the work that God gave him to do

Paragraph 1:8–12

This is the first paragraph in which Paul gave Timothy some specific examples/instructions about how he should use his gift mentioned in 1:6a. In this paragraph Paul told Timothy not to be ashamed of the gospel, but to be prepared to suffer for being a follower of Christ.

1:11a

to which I was appointed as a preacher,

- It is this good news about Jesus Christ that God has appointed/told me to preach.
- God chose me to go and tell people this good news about Jesus Christ.

1:11b

an apostle,

- He also appointed me to be an apostle
- He sent me as his representative to tell this message to people

1:11c

and a teacher.

- and a teacher of the good news.
- and to teach them about Jesus Christ.

1:11a–c

to which I was appointed as a preacher, an apostle, and a teacher: The gospel is the topic of 1:11. You should translate this verse in such a way that the focus will be on the gospel. See gospel in the Glossary.

I was appointed: God was the one who appointed Paul. Some other words for appointed are “assigned” or “chosen.”

a preacher: The Greek word that the BSB translates as preacher comes from the verb that means “to preach.” Some versions have translated this word as “herald,” a person that a king or some other important leader has appointed to announce a message publicly.

an apostle: An apostle is a person whom someone has sent to do a specific job on behalf of that sender. Paul was to represent Christ Jesus to others. See apostle in the Glossary.

a teacher: Paul not only preached the message about Jesus Christ. He also taught people the other truths

that God had revealed to him about the way Christians should behave.

2 Timothy 1:12

Section 1:3–18: Paul encouraged Timothy to continue doing the work that God gave him to do

Paragraph 1:8–12

This is the first paragraph in which Paul gave Timothy some specific examples/instructions about how he should use his gift mentioned in 1:6a. In this paragraph Paul told Timothy not to be ashamed of the gospel, but to be prepared to suffer for being a follower of Christ.

1:12a

For this reason, even though I suffer as I do,

- That is the reason why I am suffering here in prison.
- It is because I tell/preach this message about Jesus Christ to people that I am also suffering here in prison.

I suffer as I do: The clause that the BSB translates as I suffer as I do is literally “I am suffering these things.” The phrase “these things” refers to the difficulties that Paul experienced when he was in prison.

1:12b

I am not ashamed;

- But I am not ashamed that I must suffer in prison,
- But I am not embarrassed that I am a prisoner,

I am not ashamed: Paul leaves implicit what he is ashamed of. You may need to make this explicit and say, “Yet I am not ashamed of being in prison for Christ’s sake.” The word that Paul used here for I am not ashamed is the same Greek word that he used in Romans 1:16.

1:12c

for I know whom I have believed,

- because I know the one whom I have trusted,
- because I know Christ, and I continue to trust him.

for I know whom I have believed: Verse parts 1:12c and 1:12d contain two reasons why Paul was not ashamed of being in prison. The first reason (1:12c) that he was not ashamed was because he believed/trusted in Jesus Christ and he knew that Jesus was God.

1:12d

and I am convinced that He is able to guard what I have entrusted to Him for that day.

- and because I am convinced/certain that Christ is able to keep safe what he has entrusted to me until the day he returns.

- Christ entrusted/gave to me the good news. I also am sure that he is able to protect this message until the judgment day.

and I am convinced that He is able to guard...for that day: This is the second reason Paul was not ashamed. Paul was not free to travel about and preach. But he was convinced that Christ would ensure that the good news would continue to be proclaimed until the day Christ returns.

for that day: This refers to the day when Christ will return and judge all people.

Some ways to translate this phrase are “until the judgment day” or “until Christ returns.”

what I have entrusted to Him: There are two translation issues you must address before you can translate this verse.

Issue 1: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as what I have entrusted to Him is literally “my deposit.” In Greek, it is not clear in what sense the deposit was Paul’s. There are two possibilities:

1. It was Paul’s deposit because Christ entrusted the deposit to Paul. For example, GNT says:

what he has entrusted to me. See also RSV, NET, REB, GW, CEV, JBP, NCV.

1. It was Paul’s deposit because Paul entrusted the deposit to Christ. For example, the NLT says:

what I have entrusted to him. See also BSB, NIV, NRSV, NASB, KJV, NJB.

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1) for the following reason. The same word for “deposit” that appears here also appears in 1:14 and in 1 Timothy 6:20. In these other two contexts, the word clearly means something that God had entrusted to Timothy. For this reason, the versions listed under interpretation (1) above interpret “my deposit” here as something that the Lord had entrusted to Paul.

However, interpretation (2) also has strong support among the major English translations. If the major language version in your area follows interpretation (2), then you may prefer to choose it. If so, you could say,

I am convinced that Christ is able to keep safe what I have entrusted to him until the day he returns.

Whichever interpretation you choose to follow, it is recommended that you write a footnote to explain the alternative interpretation.

Issue 2: The second issue is what the deposit refers to. If you do not need to make this explicit, you can follow the GNT and say:

I am sure that he is able to keep safe until that Day what he has entrusted to me.

If you need to make explicit what the deposit is, read below.

1. If you follow interpretation (1) above, then the deposit was probably the gospel itself, which was what Paul preached and taught. Perhaps the deposit also included the people who had believed as a result of Paul’s preaching the gospel. Paul believed that God had told him to care for these people. He was sure that even after he died, true believers would continue to preach the gospel message to others and God would protect the people who had believed. If you follow this interpretation, you could say:

I am convinced that Christ is able to keep safe the gospel message until the day he returns.

1. If you follow interpretation (2), then the deposit was probably Paul’s life or his service to Christ. If you follow this interpretation you could say:

I am convinced that Christ is able to protect my service/life that I have given to him until the day he returns.

2 Timothy 1:13

Section 1:3–18: Paul encouraged Timothy to continue doing the work that God gave him to do

Paragraph 1:13–14

1:13 and 1:14 express similar ideas. Paul instructed Timothy in both verses to protect, guard, and preserve the true doctrine of the gospel.

1:13a

Hold on to the pattern of sound teaching you have heard from me,

- ¶ You have heard correct/true teaching from me. Preserve this as your model of true doctrine.
- ¶ Make sure you preserve/keep the true message that I taught you concerning what we believe. You should use it as your model/pattern.

Hold on to the pattern of sound teaching you have heard from me: Paul had taught Timothy the correct and complete gospel message. Here, he was telling Timothy to remember what he had taught him and to preserve it as the model of true doctrine.

Hold on to: Here, the phrase Hold on to means to “keep” or “preserve.” It is parallel to the word “guard” in 1:14. Hold on to implies holding on to something so that it will not be changed or lost.

pattern: The Greek word that the BSB translates as pattern only occurs in the New Testament here and in 1 Timothy 1:16. Other meanings for pattern are “model” or “example.”

In the Greek sentence, pattern occurs before the verb keep. This emphasizes this noun.

In this context, the word pattern refers to an abstract idea. It may be necessary for you to use a phrase or a clause to express this idea. Here is one way you might translate this:

The things that you have heard from me are worthy to be followed / imitated. Keep/Preserve/ Hold on to this sound teaching.

sound teaching: This phrase in Greek is literally “healthy words.” Paul was talking about true and correct doctrine, or a true and correct set of beliefs. This true and correct doctrine is the message that Paul preached to tell people that God saves them by means of Jesus Christ.

you have heard from me: The phrase you have heard from me is the direct object of the verb hold. GNT expresses this clearly: “Hold firmly to the true words that I taught you.”

General Comment on 1:13a

Some English translations imply that Paul was instructing Timothy to follow his example by teaching the same things that he taught. While this may be implied, you should not make this explicit in your translation. The emphasis here is on preserving correct doctrine, not on teaching it.

1:13b

with the faith and love that are in Christ Jesus.

- Do this with faith and love because you are united with Christ Jesus.
- As you do this, continue to believe in Jesus and to love others because you are united with Christ Jesus.

with the faith and love that are in Christ Jesus: Scholars do not agree about whether this phrase modifies the previous clause or whether it is a separate instruction. So this phrase can be understood in the following two ways:

1. It tells how Timothy was to “hold on to [what he heard from Paul] as the pattern of sound teaching.” For example, GW says:

With faith and love for Christ Jesus, consider what you heard me say to be the pattern of accurate teachings. See also BSB, NIV, RSV, NET, REB.

1. It is a separate instruction. For example, GNT says:

and remain in the faith and love that are ours in union with Christ Jesus. See also NLT, CEV.

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1) as the majority of English versions do.

the faith and love: If you want to translate these two nouns as verbs, you can say, “to believe in Jesus and to love others.” See faith in the Glossary, Meaning 1.

in Christ Jesus: The phrase in Christ Jesus means “to be united with Christ Jesus.” Paul told Timothy to continue to believe in Jesus and to love others because Timothy was united with Jesus.

2 Timothy 1:14

Section 1:3–18: Paul encouraged Timothy to continue doing the work that God gave him to do

Paragraph 1:13–14

1:13 and 1:14 express similar ideas. Paul instructed Timothy in both verses to protect, guard, and preserve the true doctrine of the gospel.

1:14a

Guard the treasure entrusted to you,

- Protect the true message that God gave to you.
- God gave/entrusted to you the good news about Jesus Christ. Defend it against attack from false teachers.

Guard: The word Guard here means to “defend against attack.”

the treasure entrusted to you: The words treasure entrusted to you are a translation of one Greek word. This is the same Greek word that Paul used in 1:12d. This word usually refers to money or land that a person entrusted to another person to keep safe. Here Paul used the word treasure to refer to the good news

about Jesus Christ. Paul combined these two ideas to tell Timothy to “defend the gospel against attack from enemies.”

1:14b

with the help of the Holy Spirit who dwells in us.

- Protect it with the help of the Holy Spirit who lives in us.^(incl)
- The Holy Spirit who is in us^(incl) will help you to protect the message so that it will not be changed.

with the help of the Holy Spirit who dwells in us:

Paul told Timothy how he was to protect the true message. Timothy was going to be able to protect the message because he had the Holy Spirit living in him just as Paul did. The Holy Spirit would help him. See holy in the Glossary, Meaning 2.

with the help of the Holy Spirit: This phrase explains how Paul wanted Timothy to guard the treasure that was entrusted to him. It means, “guard with the help of the Holy Spirit.” This is why the NIV adds the word “guard” in 1:14b. You should do what is more natural in your language—one longer sentence (see BSB, RSV, GNT), or two shorter clauses or sentences with the verb repeated.

2 Timothy 1:15

Section 1:3–18: Paul encouraged Timothy to continue doing the work that God gave him to do

Paragraph 1:15–18

In this paragraph Paul temporarily stopped giving instructions to Timothy and wrote about several people whom he had previously considered to be his friends. It is probable that these people lived in the province of Asia and that Timothy knew them. Paul contrasted a faithful friend named Onesiphorus with the people who had abandoned him.

1:15a

You know that everyone in the Province of Asia

- ¶ You are aware that many of the Christians/believers that live in the province of Asia

You know: Paul changed his theme here. He used the clause that the BSB translates as You know instead of a conjunction to indicate this change of theme. In some languages there is a word or part of a word that indicates a change in theme. In other languages this may be a phrase, or a clause or even a whole sentence. Make sure your translation indicates Paul’s change in theme here in the way that your language signals a change in the theme.

that: In the Greek text, a word that means “this” immediately follows the verb You know. It emphasizes what Paul was sure that Timothy already knew.

everyone: In this context, the word everyone is an exaggeration. It does not literally mean that all the people who lived in the province of Asia abandoned Paul. It refers here to a number of Christians whom Paul had considered to be his friends, or possibly to be followers of what he taught. He had depended on these people to help him.

This type of exaggeration is common in many languages. However, if people understand this word literally, then you may have to say something like “many believers.”

the Province of Asia: Asia was the name of a province of the Roman Empire. It was not the present day continent of Asia. The Province of Asia was a part of the country that people now call Turkey. Ephesus was the capital city of the Province of Asia, and it was the city where Timothy lived and served as a church leader.

1:15b

has deserted me,

- have abandoned/rejected me,

has deserted me: Commentators believe that the Greek verb that the BSB translates as has deserted refers to one of two things:

1. A general situation. Paul may have been thinking that people had left or abandoned him in the sense that they no longer accepted him as their leader. Or perhaps Paul was referring to those who had accepted his message at first but later turned away.
2. A specific occasion. Paul may have been thinking of a specific time when the people of the province of Asia deserted him. Perhaps they did not visit him when he was in prison or support him when he was on trial. (See 4:16.)

We cannot be sure which of these Paul was referring to, so you should not try to make either one explicit in your translation. Use a general verb such as “abandon” or one whose meaning could include or refer to as many of these situations as possible.

1:15c

including Phygelus and Hermogenes.

- even Phygelus and Hermogenes.
- Even my friends Phygelus and Hermogenes have abandoned/rejected me.

including Phygelus and Hermogenes: Phygelus and Hermogenes were the names of two men. Paul probably thought that these two men would continue to

be his friends and to help him, but they did not. He mentioned them by name because Timothy knew who they were.

2 Timothy 1:16

Section 1:3–18: Paul encouraged Timothy to continue doing the work that God gave him to do

Paragraph 1:15–18

In this paragraph Paul temporarily stopped giving instructions to Timothy and wrote about several people whom he had previously considered to be his friends. It is probable that these people lived in the province of Asia and that Timothy knew them. Paul contrasted a faithful friend named Onesiphorus with the people who had abandoned him.

1:16–18

These verses (1:16–18) are one long sentence in the original text. It will probably be necessary for you to divide it into several sentences, as the Display does.

1:16a

May the Lord grant mercy to the household of Onesiphorus,

- May the Lord do much good to Onesiphorus and all who live in his house,
- But Onesiphorus was a true friend. I pray that the Lord will be kind to him and his family,

the Lord: Here the Lord refers to “the Lord Jesus Christ.”

mercy: The word mercy means “to be kind,” “to help,” or “to have pity on.” See mercy in the Glossary, Meaning 2.

the household of Onesiphorus: The word household here refers to all the people who lived in Onesiphorus’s house as part of his family.

Onesiphorus: Onesiphorus was the name of another man. He was a faithful friend to Paul. Paul was contrasting his conduct with the conduct of the people whom he had mentioned in 1:15. The second Meaning Line of the Display for 1:16a includes a sentence that explicitly shows this contrast.

1:16b

because he has often refreshed me

- because he visited me and helped/encouraged me many times,

because he has often refreshed me: The word refreshed probably refers to ways Onesiphorus encouraged Paul while Paul was in prison. It may have included visiting him, bringing him food and being kind to him in other ways. You may have a figure of

speech in your language for the word “refresh” that will convey what Paul meant here.

1:16c

and was unashamed of my chains.

- and was not ashamed of visiting me here in prison.
- He was not ashamed to visit me, even though I am in prison and tied with chains.

and was unashamed of my chains: The BSB literally translates the Greek word for chains. In those days people punished criminals by putting them in prison and fastening metal chains to or between their hands and feet. They did this to prevent the criminals from moving around and finding a way to escape. So chains is a figure of speech meaning that Paul was in prison.

In many languages, it will be necessary not to use this figure of speech but rather follow the GNT, which says:

He was not ashamed that I am in prison

2 Timothy 1:17

Section 1:3–18: Paul encouraged Timothy to continue doing the work that God gave him to do

Paragraph 1:15–18

In this paragraph Paul temporarily stopped giving instructions to Timothy and wrote about several people whom he had previously considered to be his friends. It is probable that these people lived in the province of Asia and that Timothy knew them. Paul contrasted a faithful friend named Onesiphorus with the people who had abandoned him.

1:17a

Indeed, when he arrived in Rome,

- Instead, when he came to Rome,

Indeed: The word that the BSB translates as Indeed is the Greek conjunction *alla*. It expresses a strong contrast between 1:16c and 1:17. Other English words that express this contrast are “rather” or “instead.”

Rome: Rome was the capital city of the Roman Empire. Paul was still in prison in the city of Rome at the time he wrote this letter to Timothy.

1:17b

he searched diligently until he found me.

- he searched eagerly/diligently for me in many places until he found me.
- he exerted himself in searching for me until he discovered where I was.

he searched diligently until he found me: Onesiphorus wanted very much to find Paul. Apparently it was

very difficult for him to find the prison where Paul was. He spent a long time searching, and probably walked long distances to various places in Rome, for it was a large city.

General Comment on 1:16–17

Onesiphorus would have arrived in Rome first (17a), then searched for and found Paul (17b), and only then refreshed him (16b). In some languages it may be necessary to reorder these verses. One way to do this is:

^{17a}When Onesiphorus arrived in Rome ^{17b}he searched eagerly for me until he found me. ^{16b}He often refreshed me ^{16c}and was not ashamed of me because I was in prison. ^{16a}Therefore, may the Lord do much good to Onesiphorus and his family.

2 Timothy 1:18

Section 1:3–18: Paul encouraged Timothy to continue doing the work that God gave him to do

Paragraph 1:15–18

In this paragraph Paul temporarily stopped giving instructions to Timothy and wrote about several people whom he had previously considered to be his friends. It is probable that these people lived in the province of Asia and that Timothy knew them. Paul contrasted a faithful friend named Onesiphorus with the people who had abandoned him.

1:18a

May the Lord grant Onesiphorus His mercy on that day.

- May the Lord show Onesiphorus his great mercy/ kindness on that day of judgment!
- On the day when the Lord judges the world, may he be merciful/kind to Onesiphorus.

May the Lord grant Onesiphorus His mercy on that day: This is a blessing/prayer. In expressing this blessing/prayer, Paul was asking the Lord to repay Onesiphorus with special kindness for all that he had done for Paul in prison.

the Lord grant Onesiphorus His mercy: In Greek this phrase is more literally the Lord to him to find mercy from the Lord. The pronoun “him” refers to Onesiphorus. The Greek says the Lord twice in this sentence. Most commentators believe that the Lord refers to Christ both times. You may want to consider following the model of the BSB here and use the Lord only once and use a pronoun the second time. If you do this you may want to use the name Onesiphorus instead of the pronoun “him” as the BSB does. Do what is most natural in your language.

mercy: This refers to God’s help and kindness toward his own people in their various needs. See mercy in the Glossary, Meaning 2.

on that day: This refers to the final judgment day when Jesus will reward believers. See the notes on 1:12d and 4:8c.

1:18b

You know very well how much he ministered to me in Ephesus.

- You yourself know very well how much he helped me in Ephesus.
- You yourself are well aware of all the things that he did for me when I was in Ephesus.

You know very well how much he ministered to me in Ephesus: Some scholars describe 1:18b as an afterthought because it does not connect very logically with 1:18a. It is best to simply begin a new sentence here without trying to supply any conjunction to connect it with 1:18a.

In this part of the verse Paul was referring to a time when he and Onesiphorus had both been in the city of Ephesus.

You: The Greek pronoun *su* “you (sing)” occurs here. This adds extra emphasis. One way to show this emphasis in English is to say “you yourself.”

he ministered to me: The Greek text does not have the word *me* with the verb *ministered* in this sentence. For this reason there are two ways to understand this clause:

1. It is clear whom Onesiphorus ministered to—Onesiphorus helped Paul. Most English versions translate it as “he helped me,” because in the context Paul was writing about his personal relationship with Onesiphorus. For example, CEV says:

You know how much he helped me in Ephesus. See also BSB, NIV, GNT, KJV, NET, KJV, GW, NLT, JBP, NCV.

1. It is not clear whom Onesiphorus helped. This probably means that Onesiphorus helped many people. Some scholars think it means “he served people” without explicitly indicating whom he helped. For example, the REB says:

You know as well as anyone the many services he rendered at Ephesus. See also RSV and NASB.

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1) as the majority of English versions do.

2 Timothy 2:1

Section 2:1–13: Timothy should be willing to endure hardship as he serves Jesus Christ

Paragraph 2:1–2

In 1:13–14, Paul had told Timothy to do certain things. In 1:15–18, Paul wrote about what had happened to some of his relationships with people since the Roman authorities had put him in prison. At the beginning of chapter 2, Paul again gave Timothy some instructions. He told Timothy to:

1. be strong by means of the special ability Jesus gave him (2:1).
2. teach qualified people the message Paul had taught him (2:2).

2:1a

You therefore, my child, be strong

- ¶ You then, Timothy, my son, continue to be strong/strengthened
- ¶ As for you, Timothy, who are like my son, continue to be strong/strengthened spiritually.

You therefore: The words You therefore signal two things. One is that Paul was returning to talking to Timothy after talking about other people in 1:15–18. The other is that he was returning to his main theme of instructing Timothy.

my child: When Paul addressed Timothy as my child, Paul was expressing his affection for Timothy. If speakers of your language would think that the phrase my child means that Timothy was really Paul's son in a physical sense, you could say "you are like my child," or even "dear Timothy," or a similar phrase that people use to express affection. See the note on 1:2b.

be strong: Paul encouraged Timothy to be strong in serving Jesus Christ. When Paul said be strong he was not talking about physical strength. He was talking about inner strength or courage. He urged Timothy to be disciplined and to be willing to endure suffering as he served the Lord.

The Greek verb that the BSB translates as be strong is a passive verb. Some languages may need to make this verb active by saying:

Let God make you strong.

Let God strengthen you.

2:1b

in the grace that is in Christ Jesus.

- by means of the grace that Christ Jesus gives you.
- It is Christ Jesus who gives you the ability to be strong.

in the grace: In this verse, Paul used the word grace in a different sense than he used it in 1:9d. Here, Paul was referring to an ability that God gives to all people who trust in Christ. Paul was talking about the ability to endure suffering, to obey God, and in general to live in a way that pleases God. See grace in the Glossary, Meaning 3.

When Paul commanded Timothy to be strong in the grace, he means that Timothy should be strong "by means of the grace," "through/with the grace," or "using the grace" that Christ gives him.

that is in Christ Jesus: The phrase in Christ Jesus is ambiguous. It can mean:

1. Christ is the source of grace. Grace is provided in/by Christ Jesus. He gives us grace. For example, JBP says:

Be strong in the grace that Christ Jesus gives.

1. God gives grace to those who believe in (or are united with) Christ Jesus, that is, grace that is given (by God) to those who believe in Christ Jesus. For example, the NLT says:

Be strong with the special favor God gives you in Christ Jesus.

Most English versions translate literally the phrases in the grace that is in Christ Jesus. As a result, either of the above interpretations is possible. If possible, you should also translate so that either interpretation is possible. If you must choose one, choose interpretation (1).

General Comment on 2:1

In some languages it may be helpful to reverse the order of 2:1a and 2:1b and translate it as:

Christ Jesus gives us the ability/grace to be strong. So then, my son, be strong.

2 Timothy 2:2

Section 2:1–13: Timothy should be willing to endure hardship as he serves Jesus Christ

Paragraph 2:1–2

In 1:13–14, Paul had told Timothy to do certain things. In 1:15–18, Paul wrote about what had happened to some of his relationships with people since the Roman authorities had put him in prison. At the beginning of chapter 2, Paul again gave Timothy some instructions. He told Timothy to:

1. be strong by means of the special ability Jesus gave him (2:1).
2. teach qualified people the message Paul had taught him (2:2).

2:2

In 2:2, Paul gave Timothy the second command. This second command was that Timothy should pass this teaching on to others.

2:2a

And the things that you have heard me say

- As for the things/message about Christ that you have heard me teach
- You have heard me teaching the message about Christ to you

And the things that you have heard me say: The wording here is similar, but not identical, to 1:13a.

And: In Greek, 2:1 and 2:2 are one sentence. The word And indicates a simple coordination between the command in 2:1 and the command in this verse. Many English translations begin a new sentence here and do not include the word And.

the things: The Greek word that the BSB translates here as the things refers to the phrase “sound teaching” in 1:13. Because things is emphasized in Greek, one way to show this is to say, “As for the things you have heard me say...”

2:2b

among many witnesses,

- before many witnesses,
- and many other people.

among many witnesses: The Greek word *dia*, which the BSB translates with the phrase among, usually means “through” or “by.” So Bible scholars have different opinions about what the Greek text means here.

1. It means that Timothy had heard Paul preach and teach the gospel in front of or in the presence of many people. For example, GNT says:

Take the teachings that you heard me proclaim in the presence of many witnesses See also BSB, NIV, RSV, KJV, JBP, NET, NASB, REB.

1. It means that Timothy had heard the gospel confirmed through or by many other people. Timothy had heard the gospel message from Paul. He had also heard it from others. For example, the NLT says:

You have heard me teach many things that have been confirmed by many reliable witnesses. See also NJB, NRSV, GW, NCV.

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1).

witnesses: The witnesses are people who have seen or heard something. Here it refers to those who had heard Paul speak. They could confirm that Paul had preached the gospel and that what he said was true. This is the same word that is used in 1 Timothy 5:19 and 1 Timothy 6:12.

2:2c

entrust these to faithful men

- teach/transmit that same message to dependable/trustworthy people
- So, I want you to teach that same message to other believers whom you trust

entrust these to faithful men: The verb entrust means to “leave something valuable with other people who will keep it safe.” Here, the thing that Timothy was to entrust was the message about Jesus Christ. Paul wanted Timothy to teach that message to people whom he was certain would not change the message. These were to be people whom Timothy could trust to teach the gospel accurately to other people.

faithful: Other words for faithful are “reliable,” “trustworthy,” or “dependable.”

2:2d

who will be qualified to teach others as well.

- who will also be able to teach it to others.
- and who will know how to teach it to other people.

who will be qualified to teach others as well: The men whom Timothy was to choose were to be those who were able to teach well.

qualified: This word means “capable” or “competent.”

2 Timothy 2:3

Section 2:1–13: Timothy should be willing to endure hardship as he serves Jesus Christ

Paragraph 2:3–7

In this paragraph Paul compared Christians to three types of people in order to give Timothy three different instructions.

1. As a soldier endures hardship, endure hardship for the Lord.
2. As an athlete is self-disciplined, be self-disciplined.
3. As a farmer works hard, work hard for the Lord.

In 2:3 Paul explicitly stated one of the two main themes of the letter. That theme is that a Christian who wants to serve the Lord must be like a loyal soldier. He must be willing to endure suffering.

2:3a

Join me in suffering,

- ¶ Suffer your part/share,
- ¶ Accept/Endure suffering,

Join me in suffering: This clause is translated from one Greek verb that means, “to endure hardship with” or “to join/share in suffering.” In Greek, the verb has no explicit object, that is, it does not say with whom Timothy should suffer. Because of this, English versions differ in how they translate this verb:

1. Many English versions also leave the object implicit and use a clause that does not require an object. For example, the CEV says:

Endure your share of suffering.... See also RSV, GNT, JBP, NET, REB, NJB.

1. Some versions supply the object “us.” That is, Paul was telling Timothy to share in the suffering he and other believers were enduring. So the NIV says:

Endure hardship with us See also NCV.

1. Other versions like the BSB supply the object “me.” That is, Paul was telling Timothy to share in the suffering that he himself was enduring. So NLT says,

Endure suffering along with me.... See also NASB, GW.

If possible, you should follow option (1) like the Greek text and the majority of versions and translate it with a verb or phrase that does not require an object.

If, however, you must make explicit the people with whom Timothy was to suffer, here are some suggestions:

Endure hardship with us (NIV)

Suffer with us (excl)

2:3b

like a good soldier of Christ Jesus.

- as a good soldier of Christ Jesus suffers.
- as a good soldier of Christ Jesus accepts/endures suffering.

like a good soldier of Christ Jesus: Paul compared Christians to soldiers, because both Christians and soldiers need to endure hardship. Also both Christians and soldiers have a commander. The Christians’ commander is Christ Jesus.

2 Timothy 2:4

Section 2:1–13: Timothy should be willing to endure hardship as he serves Jesus Christ

Paragraph 2:3–7

In this paragraph Paul compared Christians to three types of people in order to give Timothy three different instructions.

1. As a soldier endures hardship, endure hardship for the Lord.
2. As an athlete is self-disciplined, be self-disciplined.
3. As a farmer works hard, work hard for the Lord.

In 2:3 Paul explicitly stated one of the two main themes of the letter. That theme is that a Christian who wants to serve the Lord must be like a loyal soldier. He must be willing to endure suffering.

2:4–6

In 2:4–6, Paul compared the Christian to three types of people. Then in 2:7 he advised Timothy to think deeply about the meaning of these three comparisons. This shows that the point of comparison in Paul’s illustrations would not be immediately clear even to Timothy. He needed to think about what Paul wrote to him. Because of this, you should avoid making the points of comparison explicit in your translation.

2:4a

A soldier refrains from entangling himself in civilian affairs,

- A soldier who is serving in the army does not do another kind of work at the same time.

- No one who is a soldier becomes involved in civilian matters,

A soldier: This refers to a soldier on active duty.

entangling himself: This phrase is the translation of one Greek verb. It occurs only here and in 2 Peter 2:20. It means “to get entangled in” or “to get mixed up with.”

in civilian affairs: This phrase is literally “matters/affairs of life.” It can refer to any matter in general, or more specifically, to a business or job that is not a military job. A soldier may have brief times when he is not actually working as a soldier, but even during those times he is not free to start working at some other kind of job.

Some other ways to translate this phrase are:

everyday matters (NCV)

non-military activities (GW)

2:4b

in order to please the one who enlisted him.

- so that he may please his commanding officer.
- because he wants to please his commanding officer.
- If he does, he will not please his commander/leader.

in order to: In the Greek text, the conjunction hina (in order to) connects 2:4a and 2:4b. There are several ways to show this connection.

- Make the conjunction implicit. The NIV uses a dash to indicate the connection between these two verse parts.

^{4a}No one serving as a soldier gets involved in civilian affairs—^{4b}he wants to please his commanding officer. Other translations (GW, CEV) begin a new sentence at 2:4b.

^{4a}Soldiers on duty don't work at outside jobs.

^{4b}They try only to please their commanding officer. (CEV)

- Make the conjunction explicit like the BSB and NASB do. For example, the NASB says:

No soldier in active service entangles himself in the affairs of everyday life, so that he may please the one who enlisted him as a soldier.

- State 2:4b negatively like the NET does.

No one in military service gets entangled in matters of everyday life; otherwise he will not please the one who recruited him. See also NLT, and JBP.

- Reorder 2:4a and 2:4b.

^{4b}A soldier wants to please his commanding officer, ^{4a}so he does not get involved in civilian affairs.

You should use the option that is most natural in your language.

the one who enlisted him: In Greek, this is literally “the one having enlisted (him).” The BSB, RSV, NASB, and NET translate this literally. However, a literal translation like “the enlistment officer” may give the wrong impression. In Paul's time, each officer gathered together (or enlisted) the men he later commanded. This was different than many of today's armies where the enlistment officer is a completely different person than the commanding officer. Therefore, a term like “commanding officer” or “commander” may be more appropriate.

General Comment on 2:4

The Christian's commanding officer is Christ. The point of the comparison between a soldier and a person who serves Christ is that the soldier and the Christian must each completely commit himself to his commander, doing whatever the commander tells him to do.

However, the point of comparison should not be made explicit in the translation because in 2:7, Paul asked Timothy to think about what he was saying and said that the Lord would help Timothy to understand it. Therefore, Paul was not trying to be completely explicit.

2 Timothy 2:5

Section 2:1–13: Timothy should be willing to endure hardship as he serves Jesus Christ

Paragraph 2:3–7

In this paragraph Paul compared Christians to three types of people in order to give Timothy three different instructions.

1. As a soldier endures hardship, endure hardship for the Lord.
2. As an athlete is self-disciplined, be self-disciplined.
3. As a farmer works hard, work hard for the Lord.

In 2:3 Paul explicitly stated one of the two main themes of the letter. That theme is that a Christian who wants to serve the Lord must be like a loyal soldier. He must be willing to endure suffering.

2:5a

Likewise, a competitor

- Also, when someone competes in a game/sport,
- Here is another example: when someone runs in a race against others

Likewise, a competitor: In this verse Paul compared Christians to athletes. Just as an athletic competitor has to follow rules when he plays a game, so Christ has given believers rules regarding their behavior. Paul made this comparison to remind Timothy that he should follow all these rules.

Likewise: The common combination of Greek conjunctions *de kai* (“and also”) connects 2:4 and 2:5. The BSB translates this phrase with the word *Likewise* to show that Paul was using another example to illustrate his point. Another way to show this connection is with the word “also,” as the NET, NASB, and NCV have done.

a competitor: This phrase is the translation of the Greek verb *athleō*. The English word “athlete” comes from this verb. It means “to compete in a contest.” This verb implies that the athlete is not merely playing a game for fun. He wants to win. Also, the verb implies that the contest was for young people or adults—Paul was not talking about a child’s game. Other ways to express this idea are:

if someone plays in a sport/game

if a runner runs a race

if anyone competes as an athlete (NIV)

2:5b–c

does not receive the crown unless he competes according to the rules.

- he does not win the prize unless he competes/runs according to the rules.
- if he does not obey the rules of the race/sport, no one will give him a prize/ reward when he finishes/ wins the game/contest.

does not receive the crown: In the sports that Paul was thinking of, the person in charge of the contest, or some other important person, placed a crown made out of leaves on the head of the winner as a symbol of victory.

If you do not have a word for “crown,” you can use a more general term, such as “prize” or “reward.”

unless he competes according to the rules: The point of the comparison in 2:5a is that there are specific rules for each sport that people who compete in that sport must obey. The person who does not obey the rules cannot win.

Another way to state this is:

if he does not follow/obey the rules

if he does not compete/play according to the rules

General Comment on 2:5

In some languages, it may be more natural to reverse the order of 2:5b and 2:5c as follows:

If he does not compete according to the rules, he does not win the victor’s crown.

It is also possible to combine 2:5a–c as follows:

Also, an athlete cannot win a prize if he does not play by the rules.

2 Timothy 2:6

Section 2:1–13: Timothy should be willing to endure hardship as he serves Jesus Christ

Paragraph 2:3–7

In this paragraph Paul compared Christians to three types of people in order to give Timothy three different instructions.

1. As a soldier endures hardship, endure hardship for the Lord.
2. As an athlete is self-disciplined, be self-disciplined.
3. As a farmer works hard, work hard for the Lord.

In 2:3 Paul explicitly stated one of the two main themes of the letter. That theme is that a Christian who wants to serve the Lord must be like a loyal soldier. He must be willing to endure suffering.

2:6a

The hardworking farmer

- A farmer who works hard

The hardworking farmer: This verse has a third comparison. In this verse Paul compared a person who serves God to a farmer. A farmer must work hard if he wants to have good crops. In the same way, Timothy

would have to work hard serving God if he wanted to receive a reward from God.

Paul was speaking in a general way about farmers. He was not talking about a specific farmer. In some languages, people do not use a definite article like the English word “the” unless they are referring to a specific person. If your language is like that, you could say “a farmer who works hard....”

2:6b

should be the first to partake of the crops.

- deserves to be the first person to receive a share/portion of the harvest.

should be the first to partake of the crops: There are two ways to interpret the word first.

1. It refers to the farmer. The hardworking farmer should be the first person to receive some of the harvest. For example, the NCV says:

The farmer who works hard should be the first person to get some of the food that was grown. See also BSB, NIV, NLT, CEV, NASB, KJV.

1. It refers to the harvest/crop. The hardworking farmer should receive the first portion of the harvest. For example, GNT says:

The farmer who has done the hard work should have the first share of the harvest. See also RSV, GW, JBP, NET.

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1).

the crops: The phrase the crops refers to the food that the farmer gathers/harvests. It is a general word referring to the harvest of any fruit, vegetable, or grain that someone has planted.

2 Timothy 2:7

Section 2:1–13: Timothy should be willing to endure hardship as he serves Jesus Christ

Paragraph 2:3–7

In this paragraph Paul compared Christians to three types of people in order to give Timothy three different instructions.

1. As a soldier endures hardship, endure hardship for the Lord.
2. As an athlete is self-disciplined, be self-disciplined.
3. As a farmer works hard, work hard for the Lord.

In 2:3 Paul explicitly stated one of the two main themes of the letter. That theme is that a Christian who wants to serve the Lord must be like a loyal soldier. He must be willing to endure suffering.

2:7a

Consider what I am saying,

- Think about the things I am saying,
- Timothy, think about what these examples teach/show,

Consider what I am saying: Paul told Timothy to Consider or “think about” the meaning of the three comparisons in 2:4–6. In some languages it may be more natural to start this command with Timothy’s name. For example, “Timothy, think about what I am saying.”

2:7b

for the Lord will give you insight into all things.

- because if you do, the Lord will help you to understand all these things.
- and the Lord will help you to understand what I mean.

for the Lord will give you insight into all things: By thinking about the soldier, the athlete, and the farmer, the Lord would help Timothy understand Paul’s illustrations. Timothy would also understand how to apply to his own ministry the lessons he learned from these comparisons.

for: The conjunction for connects 2:7a and 2:7b. This is the first word of the clause that contains the reason why Timothy was to think about what Paul was saying.

the Lord: Here the Lord refers to the Lord God.

insight: The Greek word that the BSB translates as insight also means “understanding.” This is the way most other English versions translate this word.

General Comment on 2:7a–b

Here are some other ways to translate 2:7a–b:

If you reflect on what I am saying, the Lord will help you understand all this.

Reflect on what I am saying, and the Lord will help you understand all this.

2 Timothy 2:8

Section 2:1–13: Timothy should be willing to endure hardship as he serves Jesus Christ

Paragraph 2:8–13

Paul continued his letter by reminding Timothy to endure suffering. He reminded Timothy that Jesus suffered and that Paul himself was suffering.

2:8a

Remember Jesus Christ,

- ¶ Remember continually who Jesus Christ is.
- ¶ Continually think about Jesus Christ.

Remember: The form of the Greek word that the BSB translates as Remember contains the meaning of doing something continually. So, in this context, it means, “to continue to think about.” GW expresses this clearly:

Always think about Jesus Christ.

Paul was not implying that Timothy might forget Jesus or facts about him. He wanted to remind Timothy to think about Jesus Christ continually.

Jesus Christ: This is one of the few places in Paul’s letters to Timothy that the order of the names is Jesus Christ instead of Christ Jesus. It is recommended that you keep the same order as in the Greek and the BSB. See the discussion on the order in 1:1a.

2:8b

raised from the dead,

- He has been raised from the dead,
- God raised him from the dead.

raised from the dead: This is a passive clause. In some languages, it may be necessary to say, “whom God raised from the dead” or “whom God caused to live again.”

2:8c

descended from David,

- and he is descended from King David.

descended from David: One of Jesus’ ancestors was King David. It was especially important to the Jews that Jesus was a descendant of David, because they knew that the Messiah would be a “descendant (son) of David.”

General Comment on 2:8b–c

In some languages, it may be necessary to reverse the order of 2:8b and 2:8c so that they are in chronological order. This would read as:

^{8c}He was descended from David and ^{8b}he was raised from the dead.

2:8d

as proclaimed by my gospel,

- This is the good news/message that I teach/preach to people.

as proclaimed by my gospel: The phrase my gospel refers to the message that Paul preached about Jesus. By using the phrase my gospel Paul did not mean that the gospel belonged to him or that it originated from him. In some languages, it may be necessary to say “this is the message that I preached.” See gospel in the Glossary.

General Comment on 2:8

The second theme of this letter is that Timothy should faithfully preach the true message about Jesus Christ and not allow other teachings to contradict it or to take its place. In the congregation in Ephesus, some who said they were believers were trying to teach a different message. (See 2:14–18.)

2 Timothy 2:9

Section 2:1–13: Timothy should be willing to endure hardship as he serves Jesus Christ

Paragraph 2:8–13

Paul continued his letter by reminding Timothy to endure suffering. He reminded Timothy that Jesus suffered and that Paul himself was suffering.

2:9a

for which I suffer

- because of which I am suffering.
- I am suffering because I have taught people this good news.

for: There are several ways to show the relationship between 2:8d and 2:9a. GNT uses one of the most common ways by repeating some form of 2:8d “the gospel that I preach” at the beginning of 2:9a. This way is followed in the Display. (See also GW, NLT, CEV, JBP.)

which I suffer: The Greek word that the BSB translates as suffer is related to the word translated “endure hardship” in 2:3a. It is a general word that can include all of the things Paul had endured because people tried to stop him from preaching the good news about Jesus Christ. In particular, at this time, Paul was suffering because he was in prison.

2:9b

to the extent of being chained like a criminal.

- I am even bound with chains in prison as if I were a criminal.
- I am even treated like a law-breaker and chained here in prison.

to the extent of being chained like a criminal: In those days people punished criminals by fastening metal chains to or between their hands and feet. They did this to prevent the criminals from moving around and finding a way to escape from the prison. Paul mentioned the chains earlier in 1:16c.

2:9c

But the word of God cannot be chained!

- But God's word, in contrast, is not bound/tied with chains.
- But no one can bind/chain the word of God.
- But other people will preach God's word.

But: The Greek conjunction *alla*, which the BSB translates here as *But*, signals a strong contrast between Paul's situation and God's word. If your language uses a word in addition to "but" to mark such a contrast, you may want to use it here. Some ways of showing this contrast in English are:

But God's word, in contrast...

But as for God's word....

the word of God cannot be chained!: This clause is a figure of speech. Paul meant that God's word would continue to be preached. Even though Paul himself could not travel around to preach God's word because chains held him, other Christians who were not in prison would continue to tell people the good news and teach the word of God. Neither chains nor any other thing could stop God's word from being preached.

General Comment on 2:9b–c

Some ways to translate 2:9b and 2:9c are:

- Use the word "chain" in both. For example:

They chained me like a criminal, but they cannot chain God's word.

- Use the word "prison" in both. For example:

I am in prison like a criminal, but God's word is not in prison.

- Replace the figure of speech with the direct meaning. For example:

I am chained like a criminal and cannot preach God's word, but others will preach God's word

2 Timothy 2:10

Section 2:1–13: Timothy should be willing to endure hardship as he serves Jesus Christ

Paragraph 2:8–13

Paul continued his letter by reminding Timothy to endure suffering. He reminded Timothy that Jesus suffered and that Paul himself was suffering.

2:10a

For this reason I endure all things

- So I endure all suffering
- Therefore, I continue to suffer all kinds of pain

For this reason I endure all things: The phrase *For this reason* indicates that 2:10a is the result of 2:9c. Because God's word was not chained, Paul was willing to endure suffering so that other people could hear the good news about Jesus Christ and believe in him.

all things: The words *all things* refers to what Paul suffered. He was saying that he would endure whatever suffering he might have to. He would do this so that the people God had chosen could know Jesus.

2:10b

for the sake of the elect,

- for the benefit of the people whom God has chosen,
- so that the people whom God has chosen to belong to him

the elect: The *elect* refers to the people that God has chosen to believe in him and be his special people. It is a key term and a phrase that Paul often used. In translating it, use the same expression as in Matthew 24:24; Luke 18:7; Ephesians 1:4 and Titus 1:1. Some translation possibilities are:

God's chosen people

the people God has chosen to be his own/special people

the people whom God has chosen to follow him

2:10c

so that they too may obtain the salvation that is in Christ Jesus,

- so that they also may believe in Christ Jesus and be saved,
- also may believe in Christ Jesus and he may save them

so that they too may obtain the salvation that is in Christ Jesus: God has elected/chosen many people to belong to him. However, in order for them to belong to him (in other words, to become Christians), they must still hear the gospel and believe in Christ. Paul may have been tempted to stop preaching the gospel because of his suffering. But in this clause he told Timothy the reason he would not stop: he was committed to help people to believe in Christ.

they too: The word too refers back to the fact that Paul was saved. Paul said that he endured suffering so that the elect may “also” be saved, just as he was saved.

obtain the salvation: The clause obtain the salvation is another way of saying “be saved.” For example, the CEV says, “Then God’s special people will be saved.” The Greek text does not indicate whether it is God or Christ Jesus who saves. If you must make this explicit, use Christ Jesus, as in the Display. See salvation in the Glossary, Word 2.

in Christ Jesus: In this verse, the phrase in Christ Jesus goes with the word salvation. Some ways of translating the entire phrase are:

salvation that they will receive by believing in Christ Jesus.

salvation that Christ Jesus gives to all people who believe.

Christ Jesus may save them.

2:10d with eternal glory.

- and have glory/honor that never ends.
- and provide them with splendor that lasts forever.

with eternal glory: The phrase with eternal glory refers to the honor and splendor of eternal life when we will be in the presence of God forever. See glory in the Glossary, Meaning 1.

General Comment on 2:10c–d

English versions vary widely in how they connect eternal glory to the rest of the verse. The BSB is difficult to understand here. Therefore it is recommended that you follow one of these three translations:

they also may obtain salvation in Christ Jesus with its eternal glory (RSV).

salvation that comes through Christ Jesus and brings eternal glory (GNT).

it will bring salvation and eternal glory in Christ Jesus to those God has chosen (NLT).

2 Timothy 2:11

Section 2:1–13: Timothy should be willing to endure hardship as he serves Jesus Christ

Paragraph 2:8–13

Paul continued his letter by reminding Timothy to endure suffering. He reminded Timothy that Jesus suffered and that Paul himself was suffering.

2:11–13

Many scholars consider 2:11–13 to be a poem or a hymn that Christians at that time knew well. It is recommended that you translate these verses as poetry and use the appropriate indentations for poetry in the printed edition. You should also use short sentences or clauses, as you might in a poem. While the meaning should be clear, you should avoid an overly free translation here that distracts from the poetry.

This poem or hymn consists of four lines: 2:11b, 2:12a, 2:12b, 2:13. The first two lines are promises, the second two lines are warnings.

Each line consists of a pair of clauses. (The one exception is the fourth line, which has three clauses.) The first clause in each pair begins with the word “if.” The second clause is the conclusion.

2:11a

This is a trustworthy saying:

- The following saying is true:
- These statements are true and you can trust them:

This is a trustworthy saying: A trustworthy saying means “well-known words that are true and can be trusted.” Paul used this same phrase in 1 Timothy 1:15, 3:1, 4:9. Because there are four lines in this saying, it may be necessary to use the plural “sayings” or another word like “statements.”

2:11b

If we died with Him,

- If we^(incl) have died with Christ,
- Since it is as though we^(incl) have died together with him,

If we died with Him:

we: The pronoun we refers to all Christians.

died with Him: Most scholars agree that this clause is meant figuratively. In other words, we died with Him spiritually, not literally. It means that we “died” to sin and our old habits and behavior. However, all of the major English versions translate this clause literally.

It is important to keep the figure of speech here for two reasons: (a) It is poetic, and (b) the figure of “dying with Christ” is also used elsewhere in the New Testament, particularly in Romans 6.

Him: The pronoun Him refers to Christ. In some languages it might not be clear to whom the pronoun Him refers. If that is true for your language, it may be best to follow the CEV and use the word “Christ” in place of Him.

2:11c

we will also live with Him;

- then we^(incl) will also live together with him.

we will also live with Him: The phrase live with Him continues the figure of speech from 2:11b and refers to Jesus rising from the dead. After we have “died” to sin and our old behavior, God’s promise is that we receive new spiritual life in him. This includes fellowship with Christ while on the earth and also living with him in heaven.

2 Timothy 2:12

Section 2:1–13: Timothy should be willing to endure hardship as he serves Jesus Christ

Paragraph 2:8–13

Paul continued his letter by reminding Timothy to endure suffering. He reminded Timothy that Jesus suffered and that Paul himself was suffering.

2:12a

if we endure,

- If we^(incl) endure suffering,
- If we^(incl) continue to suffer for his sake,

if we endure: The word endure here refers to enduring whatever suffering may come to us, and to continuing to be loyal disciples of Jesus Christ despite this suffering. It is the same verb that the BSB translates as “endure” in the phrase “endure all things” in 2:10a.

2:12b

we will also reign with Him;

- we^(incl) will also rule with him like kings.

we will also reign with Him: By the words we will also reign with Him, Paul was referring to the future when Christians will rule the earth with Christ. In

1 Corinthians 6:2 Paul said that when Christ comes again, believers will judge the world.

2:12c

if we deny Him,

- But if we^(incl) deny that we know him,
- By contrast if we^(incl) say that we^(incl) are not his followers,

if we deny Him: To deny Him means “to deny that we know Christ” or “to deny that we are his followers.” This is the opposite of enduring suffering for Christ’s sake.

2:12d

He will also deny us;

- he also will deny that he knows us.
- he also will say that we^(incl) do not belong to him.

He will also deny us: This means that Christ will also deny that he knows us. This statement is similar to the words of Jesus in Matthew 10:33: “But whoever disowns me before men, I will disown him before my Father in heaven.” (See also Luke 12:9.)

2 Timothy 2:13

Section 2:1–13: Timothy should be willing to endure hardship as he serves Jesus Christ

Paragraph 2:8–13

Paul continued his letter by reminding Timothy to endure suffering. He reminded Timothy that Jesus suffered and that Paul himself was suffering.

2:13a

if we are faithless,

- Even if we^(incl) are not faithful to Christ,
- If we^(incl) do not do all that he said we should do,

if we are faithless: All major English versions translate the Greek verb as “faithless,” “unfaithful,” or “not faithful.” However, scholars still disagree about what it means to be faithless. The two main views are:

1. It means to continue to be a Christian but in some way fail to be faithful to Christ. In other words, it means to be disloyal, or to sin.
2. It means to stop being a Christian. In other words, it means to no longer have faith, or to stop believing in Christ.

It is recommended that you choose a word for faithless that includes the first meaning.

2:13b

He remains faithful,

- he remains faithful to us,

- he nevertheless does all that he has said he would do,

He remains faithful: Scholars have understood this part of the verse in two ways:

1. It is a promise—Christ remains faithful in the sense that he continues to love believers and have mercy on them even when they are temporarily unfaithful.
2. It is a warning—Christ remains faithful in the sense that he will carry out his promise to disown and punish those who have not repented of their sin.

It is recommended that you translate in a way that readers will understand interpretation (1). It is also recommended that you repeat the same root form for the word faithful as you used for the word “faithless” in 2:13a. This should be done in order to maintain the parallelism of the poem/hymn. See faith in the Glossary, Meaning 3.

remains: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as remains is in the present tense. Speakers of Greek often used the present tense form of a verb when what they said was a general truth valid at all times. You should use the present tense, as do most other English versions, unless another tense is needed to express general truths in your language.

2:13c for He cannot deny Himself.

- because he cannot contradict himself.
- for he must be who he is.

for He cannot deny Himself: This part of 2:13 is the reason why the hymn writer, Paul, is so certain that “Christ remains faithful.”

You may need to translate without the double negative in this clause. In such a case you could say something like, “for he must be who he is.”

deny Himself: The Greek word that the BSB translates as deny is the same as the Greek word translated “deny” in 2:12. However, it may not be possible to translate it in the same way here. Here the sense of deny Himself is that Christ cannot deny or break his promises. He cannot say one thing and do another; he cannot contradict himself. JBP says:

He cannot deny his own nature.

2 Timothy 2:14

Section 2:14–26: Timothy should be a workman who pleases God

Paragraph 2:14–19

Paul was writing only to Timothy here, so the verbs are singular.

2:14a

Remind the believers of these things,

- ¶ Repeatedly tell/teach the believers these things.
- ¶ Timothy, remind the believers of these things I have said/written.

Remind: The form of the Greek verb that the BSB translates as Remind indicates that Paul was asking Timothy to never stop reminding the believers about these things.

the believers: The word believers refers to the entire group of believers in Ephesus and across the province of Asia.

these things: The phrase these things refers back to what Paul had already said, and not to the text that follows. However, Bible scholars are not certain how many of the previous verses Paul was referring to here. He was referring at least to the hymn in 2:11–13. He may also have been referring to all that he had written up to this point. It is best to translate in a general sense so that 2:14a is not limited to any specific thing that Paul mentioned earlier in this letter.

2:14b

charging them before God

- Warn/tell them in the presence of God
- Warn/command them, “In the presence/name of God I tell you

charging them before God: This phrase is similar to the wording in 1 Timothy 5:21.

before God: This phrase means “in the presence of God.” It is a type of oath that Paul and other people normally used to emphasize that what they said was true. (See Galatians 1:20.) Here, however, Paul instructed Timothy to use this phrase when he talked to the believers in order to emphasize how important his warning was. See the Display for an example of translating this as direct speech.

Some other ways to translate this phrase are:

with God as your witness (CEV)

in the name of God (NJB)

God: There is a textual issue here.

1. Some Greek manuscripts have God. These manuscripts are followed by the BSB, NIV, GNT, NRSV, NJB, GW, NLT, CEV, JBP, NCV, NET, NASB, and REB.
2. Other Greek manuscripts have Lord. These manuscripts are followed by the RSV and KJV.

It is recommended that you follow option (1) as the majority of English versions do.

2:14c

to avoid quarreling over words,

- not to argue with one another about the meaning of words.
- not to fight about words.”

quarreling over words: The verb phrase quarreling over words is a translation of a single Greek verb. It means, “to strongly disagree about the meaning of words and the proper way to use them.” Paul warned Timothy in a similar way in 1 Timothy 6:4.

Paul could have been referring to the small details of words that do not change the meaning of doctrines. Or he may have been referring to myths, genealogies, and other cultural ideas that he mentioned in 1 Timothy 1:4 and 4:7.

2:14d

which succeeds only

- That kind of quarreling/arguing is completely useless,
- That kind of quarreling does not benefit anyone at all.

(NASB) which is useless: When people argued over unimportant differences in meaning, it would not help those who were listening to better understand the word of God. Such arguments were useless.

A literal translation of this phrase from Greek into English is “for nothing useful/beneficial.” The phrase “for nothing” occurs before the word “useful.” This gives “for nothing” extra emphasis. One way to show this emphasis in English would be to say “no good at all.”

2:14e

in leading the listeners to ruin.

- and it causes harm to those people who are listening.
- In fact, it ruins/injures the faith of those who listen.

(NASB) in leading the listeners to ruin: The people who argued about differences in meaning that were not important might confuse the people who listened to them. This confusion could ruin the listeners’ faith.

2 Timothy 2:15

Section 2:14–26: Timothy should be a workman who pleases God

Paragraph 2:14–19

Paul was writing only to Timothy here, so the verbs are singular.

2:15a

Make every effort to present yourself approved to God,

- Work hard so that you are able to present/show yourself to God as someone of whom he can approve.
- Work hard to show God that you are worthy of his approval.
- Work hard so that when you show yourself to God, he will say, “Well done.”

Make every effort: Make every effort is an English phrase that translates one Greek verb. It means, “to work hard,” “to try hard,” or “to put the most effort that you can into your work.”

to present yourself...to God: The verb to present means “to show” or “to stand before.”

The text does not indicate whether Paul was instructing Timothy concerning “presenting” himself to God in the present time or the future. Some scholars think this verse refers to the future judgment day when people will stand before God. Others think this refers to Timothy daily presenting himself to God. It is best to leave the time vague.

approved to God: The word approved is an adjective in Greek. It means, “accepted after successfully passing a trial or examination.” God is the one who examines how a person represents him and teaches his word. Timothy must live and teach in the ways he knew that God approved. Then he will be an approved workman of God.

As mentioned above regarding the words “present yourself,” we do not know if Paul is speaking of the past, the present or the future. It may be that God had (already) approved of Timothy as his servant or “workman.” On the other hand, the NCV uses the future: “give yourself to God as the kind of person he will accept.” If possible, do not be specific about the time. One possibility is to say:

Present yourself to God in such a way that he can approve you.

2:15b**an unashamed workman**

- Be like a workman/craftsman who works well and who does not need to be ashamed-of/embarrassed-by his work,
- Be a worker who can be proud of his work,

an unashamed workman: This part of the verse describes someone of whom God approves. In some languages, it may be best to follow the example of the NLT and start a new sentence here.

Be a good worker, one who does not need to be ashamed

workman: The word in the Greek text that the BSB translates as workman can refer to a person who does general physical work, such as carrying things or digging. But it can also refer to a person whose work requires special skill. Paul here compared Timothy and the way he was working for the Lord to a craftsman who worked well so that he was not ashamed of what he had done.

2:15c**who accurately handles the word of truth.**

- and who accurately/correctly handles the word of truth.
- and be a worker who correctly/carefully teaches the true message.

who accurately handles the word of truth: This part of the verse also describes someone of whom God approves. Here Paul again mentioned the second theme of his letter to Timothy: the message about the good news is a special thing that God has entrusted to his people. Those who teach the word of God must never mix erroneous teaching with it.

accurately handles the word of truth: The Greek word that the BSB translates as accurately handles literally means “to cut straight.” This word further develops the image of a worker in 2:15b. A worker who is not ashamed is one who skillfully uses his tools. Here the “tool” that a Christian worker must correctly handle is the word of truth. Used figuratively, this word refers to “correct teaching.” You have several options for translating this word.

- Keep the figure of speech of a worker and translate it “correctly handles” (NIV) or “accurately handles” (BSB and NASB). See also JBP.
- Replace the figure of speech with the direct meaning and translate it “correctly teach” (GNT) or “correctly explain” (NLT). See also the NCV.

word of truth: This phrase means the same as the “word of God” or the “gospel.”

2 Timothy 2:16**Section 2:14–26: Timothy should be a workman who pleases God****Paragraph 2:14–19**

Paul was writing only to Timothy here, so the verbs are singular.

2:16a**But avoid irreverent, empty chatter,**

- But you should not join in profane and empty discussions with people,
- Avoid talking in an ungodly, worthless way.

But: In Greek, this verse begins with the conjunction *de*, which the BSB translates as *But* (see also NET, JBP). For reasons of style, many English translations such as the NIV omit the conjunction here. The *de* shows the contrast that Paul was making between the positive statements in 2:15 (“Make every effort” and “the word of truth”) and the negative statement in 2:16a (“Avoid godless chatter”).

avoid: The word *avoid* means that Paul was warning Timothy to stay away from, and not to join in, discussions with people who did not show any evidence that they trusted in God or revered him.

irreverent, empty chatter: The BSB translates two words in the Greek text here as *irreverent*, *empty chatter*. These same two words are found in 1 Timothy 6:20. In both places, the words are plural. This is significant in interpreting 2:16b. See interpretation (2) below.

irreverent: The word *irreverent* refers to something that is “secular,” “profane,” or “unholy,” to something that does not honor God.

empty chatter: The noun the BSB translates as *empty chatter* means “foolish, empty, idle talk,” “talk about topics that are not important or have no value.”

2:16b**which will only lead to more ungodliness,**

- because those people who participate in godless discussions will become even more ungodly,
- The people who do that will become more and more ungodly/corrupt.

which will only lead to: Paul gave Timothy two reasons why he should avoid irreverent, empty chatter. The first reason is here in 2:16b. The second reason is in 2:17a.

which will only lead to more ungodliness,: In Greek, this clause is literally “because to more they-will-increase of ungodliness.” Scholars disagree about whom the subject “they” of the verb “will increase” refers to. There are two interpretations:

1. “they” refers to the people who talk in godless ways. Those who follow this interpretation say that this verse means that the people who chatter in ungodly ways will become more ungodly. For example, the NET says:

because those occupied with it will stray further and further into ungodliness.... See also NIV, GW, REB, and most commentaries.

1. “they” refers to the irreverent, empty chatter or discussions. Those who follow this interpretation say that this verse means that godless chatter will increase and lead people into more ungodliness. For example, the NCV says:

because that will lead people further away from God. See also BSB, RSV, GNT, NJB, NLT, CEV, JBP, NASB.

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1) as do the majority of commentaries.

more: Because this word occurs first in the clause, it has emphasis. Another way to show this emphasis in English is to translate the word as “more and more” or “even more.”

2 Timothy 2:17

Section 2:14–26: Timothy should be a workman who pleases God

Paragraph 2:14–19

Paul was writing only to Timothy here, so the verbs are singular.

2:17a

and the talk of such men will spread like gangrene.

- and because their words/message will spread and damage people, like an open sore spreads and infects a person.
- Their empty words are like an infected wound that causes a person’s whole body to become ill/infected.
- and because more and more people will hear their message/words, and this will damage the people who listen to it/them.

and: The Greek text begins this verse with the conjunction *kai*, which is often translated and. Some English

translations (BSB, RSV, NET, GW, NASB, REB) begin this verse with and to show that 2:17a is connected with 2:16.

the talk of such men will spread: This is the second reason why Timothy should avoid empty chatter.

the talk of such men: The Greek word that the BSB translates as talk is literally “word.” Here it refers to the “empty chatter” in 2:16a. The words “teaching” or “message” are other ways to translate this word.

will spread: The verb phrase will spread means that if the false teachers continued to talk, their message would go out to a wider area and deceive more and more people.

like gangrene: The word gangrene is a medical term. It refers to the decay of body tissue that is caused by an infection or disease.

Paul used gangrene as a figure of speech. Paul was comparing the false teaching to an infected wound. If no one tries to cure the infected wound, the infection will spread to more and more of the person’s body until it poisons him and eventually kills him. In the same way, if Timothy allowed the false teachers to continue teaching false doctrines, more and more people would believe their message and would stop believing the true message. In this way, those people would die spiritually.

If you cannot keep the figure of speech, you can say something like:

their words will spread and eventually destroy the faith of the people who listen to it.

more and more people will hear their teaching and it will damage those who pay attention to it.

2:17b

Among them are Hymenaeus and Philetus,

- Two of the people who teach this kind of message are Hymenaeus and Philetus.

Among them are Hymenaeus and Philetus: This is the first time in this letter that Paul mentioned the names of any of the false teachers. He had spoken of them in 2:17a when he mentions “the talk of such men.” Hymenaeus and Philetus were two of the people who had been teaching the believers ideas that were contrary to the truths of the word of God. Apparently, Timothy knew who both of these men were. Paul mentioned Hymenaeus in 1 Timothy 1:20 and indicated

that he had removed Hymenaeus from the Christian congregation in Ephesus.

2 Timothy 2:18

Section 2:14–26: Timothy should be a workman who pleases God

Paragraph 2:14–19

Paul was writing only to Timothy here, so the verbs are singular.

2:18a

who have deviated from the truth.

- They have strayed/departed from the truth.
- These two men have stopped believing the true message.

who have deviated from the truth: Apparently these two men had at one time professed to believe the message about Jesus Christ. But the things they were teaching people at the time that Paul wrote this letter were not true.

deviated from: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as deviate from originally meant “to miss the mark.” Later it came to mean “to miss, fail, deviate, and depart.” This verb occurs in 1 Timothy 1:6 also.

2:18b

They say that the resurrection has already occurred,

- They say that the resurrection has already happened.
- They say that we^(incl) believers have already been resurrected.
- These men teach that God has already raised us^(incl) believers from the dead symbolically/spiritually.

They say that the resurrection has already occurred: Here Paul specifically mentioned one of the teachings of the false teachers. They taught that the resurrection had already happened.

the resurrection: In the New Testament, the word resurrection can refer to:

1. the specific, future, universal resurrection of human beings. This term is usually preceded by the definite article: “the resurrection” (John 11:24),
2. the resurrection of Jesus from the grave three days after he was buried (Matthew 27:53).

Here it refers to (a), the resurrection of human beings. The teaching about the resurrection includes the ideas of eternal life, fellowship with God, and rewards for living in a way that pleases God.

has already occurred: Scholars do not agree about what the false teachers meant when they said that the resurrection had already occurred. However, most scholars say that these heretics taught the following: when people believed the good news about Jesus Christ, God “resurrected” them symbolically or spiritually. This heretical teaching implied that since the resurrection was symbolic only, believers could not look forward to life in a resurrected, physical body after they died.

Try to leave all this information implicit in your translation. You may want to consider putting it in a footnote.

2:18c

and they undermine the faith of some.

- As a result, they are ruining the faith of some of the believers.
- As a result, they are causing some of the believers to stop believing in Christ’s teachings.

and they undermine the faith of some: Apparently some of the people in the congregation at Ephesus had believed this new teaching and now doubted what they had believed before.

undermine: The verb that the BSB translates as undermine means “destroy,” “to overthrow” or “to overturn.” This same verb is used in Titus 1:11 where the BSB translates it as “undermine.”

According to 1 Corinthians 15:12–19, a key element of the Christian faith is belief in the resurrection of the body. So when the false teachers convinced people that there would be no resurrection of the body, they were indeed “undermining their faith.”

The verb for undermine is in the present tense. This indicates that at the time Paul was writing this letter to Timothy, these false teachers were actively deceiving believers.

faith: Here, Paul used the word faith in the sense of the basic teachings that Christians believe and practice. The false teachers were causing the believers to stop believing in Christ and his teachings. See faith in the Glossary, Meaning 2.

2 Timothy 2:19

Section 2:14–26: Timothy should be a workman who pleases God

Paragraph 2:14–19

Paul was writing only to Timothy here, so the verbs are singular.

2:19a**Nevertheless, God's firm foundation stands,**

- But God's foundation is strong and is not ruined.
- However, God's people are like a foundation that does not move.
- In spite of all that, God's people always continue to believe.

Nevertheless: The Greek word that the BSB translates as Nevertheless indicates a strong contrast with 2:16–18. The idea is that heretics might destroy the faith of some believers, but they cannot destroy God's foundation. Other English versions translate this word as “but” or “however.”

God's firm foundation stands: In some cultures, people who are constructing a building begin by putting large stones in the ground as a foundation. Then they build the walls of the building on this foundation. This causes the building to be more stable. Here, Paul used the image of a foundation in a figurative sense.

He was referring to the church, that is, the people who believe the teachings of Jesus. In the same way that the foundation stones of a building never move, the body of true believers always continues to trust firmly in Christ.

There are several options for translating this phrase:

- Translate it literally using the figure of a foundation, as many English translations do.
- Translate the phrase using a simile. In this case, you will have to refer to the church/believers as part of the translation. For example,

The true believers in God are strong in their faith like the strong foundation of a building.

- Replace the figure of speech with the direct meaning. An example of this would be:

God's people always stand/remain firm.

God's people always continue to believe the truth.

stands: Most English versions translate the Greek verb as “stands,” “stands firm,” or “remains standing.” The idea is that the foundation cannot break, nor can anyone destroy it.

This verb indicates that the church consists of people who have believed and continue to strongly believe the message of God's word even when others have chosen to stop believing it.

2:19b**bearing this seal:**

- These two sayings are written on this foundation:
- On this foundation God wrote these words:
- God has said/written:

bearing this seal: Paul continued to use the figure of speech of a foundation.

The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as bearing this seal is literally “having this seal.” In the time of Paul, people would make a mark or carve words on the foundation stones of a building to show who owned the building. Sometimes the writing also told the purpose of the building. This mark or writing was called a “seal.”

In cultures where people do not build on large stones or write on them, you may need to supply a footnote. This footnote could describe buildings that people build on stone foundations and it could explain what these stones are for. The note could also say what kinds of things people write on the foundation stones of their buildings.

2:19c**“The Lord knows those who are His,”**

- The first saying is: “The Lord knows which people are his.”
- “The Lord knows which people really belong to him.”

“The Lord knows those who are His”: This saying comes from Numbers 16:5 in the Greek translation of the Old Testament. It means that God knows which people believe firmly in him. He knows who is part of his church and who is not.

Lord: The word Lord refers to God.

2:19d**and, “Everyone who calls on the name of the Lord must turn away from iniquity.”**

- And “When someone says ‘The Lord is my master,’ that person must abandon evil.”
- And the other saying is: “Those who say that they are followers of the Lord must stop doing wrong/evil.”

and, “Everyone who calls on the name of the Lord must turn away from iniquity”: Various parts of this saying resemble parts of verses in the Old Testament, but there is no one verse in the Old Testament that contains this entire saying. Therefore, it is uncertain whether Paul wanted to quote from the Old Testament or whether he made this a summary statement of principles from the Old Testament. Nevertheless, because it is one of the two sayings that Paul lists, use

the same form of punctuation as you did in the first saying.

calls on the name of the Lord: The Greek phrase which the BSB translates as calls on the name of the Lord means that the person claims that the Lord is his/her master or leader. TEV says: “Whoever says that they belong to the Lord must turn away from wrongdoing.”

the Lord: As in 2:19c, the Lord here refers to God.

turn away from iniquity: The Greek word that the BSB translates as turn away also means “abandon,” “desert,” or “renounce.” The NCV translates this clause clearly when it says: “must stop doing wrong.”

2 Timothy 2:20

Section 2:14–26: Timothy should be a workman who pleases God

Paragraph 2:20–21

In this paragraph, Paul compared the church to a house. He also compared Christians to various types of utensils in a house.

Normally, Paul used the term “church” to refer only to the group of true believers. This paragraph may be the only place in the New Testament where Paul spoke of the church (“house”) in a broad sense that included not only true believers, but also those who claim to be believers.

The figurative language extends over two verses, so you need to try to retain the image.

2:20a

A large house contains not only vessels

- ¶ In a big house, some pots and dishes
- ¶ In the home of a wealthy person, not all the pots and dishes

In Greek the verse begins with the conjunction *de* that the BSB has left untranslated. The *de* indicates that Paul was changing from one figure of speech (a foundation in 2:19) to another figure (a house). Some English versions have tried to indicate the change of figure with the conjunction “Now,” like the NASB has done. But here, the English word “Now” does not have its normal meaning of “at this time.” Rather, it indicates a connection between topics, not simply between sentences. Many English versions omit translating the conjunction but indicate the change of subject by beginning a new paragraph.

A large house: The term large house refers to the house of a rich person. The NLT translates this term as “wealthy home.”

vessels: The term vessels here refers to things like dishes, bowls, and jars. Some languages have a generic term like “containers” or “articles” for all of these items. Other languages do not have one generic word but can list some specific items, as in GNT, which says, “dishes and bowls of all kinds.”

There are many different kinds of dishes, bowls, and other containers in the house of a wealthy person. In the same way, there are many different types of people in the church.

2:20b

of gold and silver,

- are made of gold, and some pots and dishes are made of silver.
- are made of gold or of silver.

2:20c

but also of wood and clay.

- There are others that are made of wood or pottery/clay.
- Some pots and dishes are made of wood and clay.

2:20b–c

of gold and silver, but also of wood and clay: The dishes and pots are not all of equal value. Some of these containers are made of expensive materials, such as gold and silver. Other containers are made of cheap materials, such as wood and clay.

The two types of containers represent various types of people in the church. Another interpretation is that the two types of containers represent different roles that people have in the church. See also the footnotes at 2:20d and 2:20e.

2:20d

Some indeed are for honorable use,

- Some containers are used for honorable purposes
- People use the gold and silver containers for respectable purposes,

Some indeed are for honorable use: For the phrase that the BSB translates as honorable use means that people used the containers made of gold and silver for special foods when they were celebrating or when they were entertaining guests.

The containers made of gold and silver represent the true believers in the church. This interpretation is followed by the NIV, RSV, NET, NASB, KJV, GW, and the NJB. A second interpretation of the term “noble” is that it means “special.” According to this interpretation, the gold and silver containers are those used for special occasions. For example, GNT says, “some are for special occasions.” (See also NRSV, NLT, NCV, CEV.)

According to this view, the containers used for special events represent those believers who have the more spectacular spiritual gifts such as prophesy.

2:20e

but others are for common use.

- and other containers are used for dishonorable purposes.
- and they use the wood and clay containers for lowly/shameful purposes.
- and they use the wood and clay containers for garbage and other dirty things.

but others are for common use: The Greek word that the BSB translates as common means “dishonorable,” “disgraceful,” or “shameful.” It is the opposite of the term “honorable” that Paul used in 2:20d. People used these containers for dirty things like garbage or excrement.

The common containers (those made of wood and clay) represent false teachers, such as those to whom Paul has referred in 2:17–18. This interpretation is followed by the NIV, RSV, NET, NASB, KJV, and GWA. A second interpretation of the term “ignoble” is that it means “ordinary.” According to this interpretation, the wood and clay containers are those used for common or everyday events. For example, GNT says, “others for ordinary use.” (See also NRSV, NLT, NCV.) According to this view, the containers used for everyday events represent those believers who have ordinary or less spectacular gifts.

2 Timothy 2:21

Section 2:14–26: Timothy should be a workman who pleases God

Paragraph 2:20–21

In this paragraph, Paul compared the church to a house. He also compared Christians to various types of utensils in a house.

Normally, Paul used the term “church” to refer only to the group of true believers. This paragraph may be the only place in the New Testament where Paul spoke of the church (“house”) in a broad sense that included not only true believers, but also those who claim to be believers.

The figurative language extends over two verses, so you need to try to retain the image.

2:21a

So if anyone cleanses himself of what is unfit,

- Therefore, if anyone thoroughly cleans himself from what is dishonorable/dirty,

- In the same way, the believer who separates himself from all those bad things

So: At the beginning of 2:21a, Paul used a Greek conjunction *oun*, which means “therefore” or “so.” This conjunction connects 2:20 and 2:21 and indicates that Paul was going to interpret the image in 2:20. Many English versions omit this word, but it is recommended that you translate this conjunction so that readers understand the purpose of 2:21. You can follow the example of the BSB (So) or the NASB (“Therefore”). If you need a more explicit way to show that Paul was explaining his image, you can say something like “The lesson is that...” or “In the same way....”

if anyone cleanses himself: The Greek word that the BSB translates as cleanses means “to thoroughly clean.” It is a rare word that occurs only here and in 1 Corinthians 5:7. Paul used the word cleanses in a spiritual sense. It means that someone has cleansed (or removed) sin from his life or that he has repented from sin. In this context, the sin was accepting the false teachers and their doctrines.

of what is unfit: In the Greek text, this phrase is literally “from these.” There are two views about the meaning of the word “these.”

1. It refers specifically to the common purposes that Paul mentioned at the end of 2:20. In this view, the phrase means that believers should stay away from the false teachers and their doctrines. For example, the RSV says,

If any one purifies himself from what is ignoble...
See also NIV, NET.

1. It refers to evil or wickedness in general that Paul mentioned in 2:16–19d. For example, the REB says,

Anyone who cleanses himself from all this wickedness... See also GNT, CEV, NCV, JBP.

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1).

2:21b

he will be a vessel for honor:

- he will be like a container used for noble/honorable purposes.
- will be like a fine/valuable dish/bowl that people/we^(incl) use for a celebration,

he will be a vessel for honor: Paul continued to use the same figure of speech. The word he refers to Christians who reject false teachers and their doctrines.

Paul compared these Christians to containers/vessels that are for honor.

vessel: This is the same word as in 2:20a and refers to the containers that are made of gold and silver.

honor: This is the same term in Greek as in 2:20d-e. It refers to containers that people used for special food.

2:21c

sanctified, useful to the Master,

- He has been made holy, and so his owner/master will be able to use him.
- His life will be holy/pure, and so his owner/master will be able to use him.

sanctified: The Greek word that the BSB translates as sanctified means “set apart,” or “reserved” “made holy” for God’s use. See holy in the Glossary, Meaning 1.

This verb is passive. The text does not say who sanctified the person, so if possible, you should use a passive verb. If, however, you need to supply a subject, you can say something like “The Master has made him holy....” If you need to make it active instead of passive you can say, “His life will be pure.”

useful: The Master can “use” a person who is holy.

the Master: Here Paul continued the figure of speech about a house. The Master represents God. Paul compared God, who is the Christians’ master, to the master/owner of the house.

2:21d

and prepared for every good work.

- He is prepared/ready to do any kind of good deed.

and prepared for every good work: The Greek word that the BSB translates as prepared is literally “having been prepared.” It is a passive verb. As with the term “sanctified” in 2:21c, the text does not say who “prepared” the person. If necessary, you can say:

The Master has prepared him for any good deed.

However, a better way to translate prepared is to use a verb that means “to be ready.” For example, the NLT says:

you will be ready for the Master to use you for every good work.

2 Timothy 2:22

Section 2:14–26: Timothy should be a workman who pleases God

Paragraph 2:22–26

In this paragraph, Paul instructed Timothy regarding how he could be a “container” that God can use.

2:22a

Flee from youthful passions

- ¶ Timothy, run from doing the evil things that other young people want to do.
- ¶ So, avoid the sinful passions that attract young people,

This verse begins with the Greek conjunction *de*, which can be translated But (NET, NCV) or “so” (RSV). It indicates that Paul was changing his topic from the figure of speech about the different containers and their uses to another topic. Many English versions, including BSB, NIV and GNT, do not translate this conjunction, but indicate the change of topic by beginning a new paragraph.

Flee from: Other ways to translate the verb phrase Flee from are “run from,” “stay away from,” or “avoid.”

In the figure of speech about the containers in a large house, Paul had indirectly encouraged Timothy. Here with the verb Flee he directly commanded him. If the change seems too abrupt, perhaps your language has a way to mark this change. One way to do this is to begin the command with “Timothy” as you will see in the first Meaning Line of the Display.

youthful passions: The phrase youthful passions means “the evil things that young people want to do.” The NLT translates this phrase “youthful lusts” and the NIV translates it as “evil desires of youth.”

passions: Other ways of translating the word that the BSB translates as passions are “desires” and “impulses.” Paul was probably referring to sexual desires. He may also have been referring to selfish ambition, impatience, and doing unwise, impulsive things.

2:22b

and pursue righteousness,

- Instead, run towards what is right,
- and make an effort to do what is right and just,

pursue: The verb pursue is the opposite of “flee” in 2:22a. Flee means “to run away from,” and pursue means “to run towards.” Paul used these two verbs figuratively. He used “flee” to mean, “do not...” and pursue to mean, “make an effort to....” The NLT says: “Follow anything that makes you want to do right.”

The four abstract nouns that follow the word pursue describe character traits that Paul urged Timothy to develop. It may be necessary for you to use verb phrases or complete clauses to express what these abstract nouns mean.

righteousness: Because Paul was talking about character traits here, righteousness in this context probably refers to the way that we behave. It means “to live in a way that God considers right, and to do what is right and just to other people.” Paul was probably not talking here about the righteousness that God attributes to us because we trust in Jesus Christ. That kind of righteousness does not depend on our good character or on anything that we have done or could do. See also righteousness in the Glossary, Meaning 1.

2:22c

faith, love, and peace,

- be faithful/dependable, love other people, and live in peace with them.

faith: It is not clear in which sense Paul used this word here. There are two interpretations:

1. It means “faithfulness,” that is, being honest, truthful, and dependable either toward God or other people.
2. It means “belief or trust in God.”

If possible, translate in a general way so that people could understand both interpretations. If that is not possible and you must make a choice, choose interpretation (1). See faith in the Glossary, Meaning 3.

love: In this context, love refers to love for other people, not love for God.

peace: The word peace refers to living in harmony with other people.

2:22d

together with those who call on the Lord out of a pure heart.

- You are to pursue these things along with the people who worship the Lord with a clean heart.
- You and those who worship/pray to the Lord with sincerity are to pursue these things.

together with those who call on the Lord out of a pure heart: Scholars disagree about what this phrase goes with. There are two interpretations:

1. It applies to all four nouns that follow the verb “pursue.” So both Timothy and those who call on the Lord are to pursue righteousness, faith, love, and peace.

2. It applies only to the word peace. So Timothy is to live in peace with those who call on the Lord.

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1).

those who call on the Lord: This phrase means “people who pray to the Lord.” It refers to those who follow the Lord and worship him. It is similar to the phrase “everyone who confesses the name of the Lord” in 2:19d.

the Lord: Here the Lord probably refers to God.

a pure heart: The term pure heart means “sincerely” or “without deceit.” In many languages there is an idiom to express this aspect of a person’s character. Consider whether your language also uses an idiom. Use it if it is appropriate.

General Comment on 2:22

One possible way to translate 2:22 is to put 2:22d earlier in the verse as follows:

Timothy, run away from the evil things that other young men do. You and those who worship the Lord with clean hearts should search for ways to do what is right, faithful, loving, and peaceful.

2 Timothy 2:23

Section 2:14–26: Timothy should be a workman who pleases God

Paragraph 2:22–26

In this paragraph, Paul instructed Timothy regarding how he could be a “container” that God can use.

2:23a

But reject foolish and ignorant speculation,

- Avoid foolish and ignorant arguments,
- When people argue about foolish and irrelevant things, do not participate,

But reject: The Greek verb the BSB translates as reject means “avoid,” or “refuse,” or “don’t have anything to do with.”

foolish and ignorant: The Greek words that the BSB translates as foolish and ignorant are synonyms.

foolish: The word “fool” in the Bible often means “a person who does not know what God is like or who perhaps does not even believe that he exists.” The word foolish here refers to the kinds of things such a person says or does. (See Luke 12:20 and 1 Corinthians 15:36.)

ignorant: The Greek word that the BSB translates as ignorant means “uneducated,” “stupid” or “uninstructed.”

(NIV) arguments: In certain contexts, the Greek word used here could be translated as “speculation” (as in the BSB), or “discussion” or “debate.” In this case, however, the word has a negative meaning of “controversies” or “arguments.” This is why the NIV is recommended as a reference to translate this word.

2:23b

for you know that it breeds quarreling.

- because you know that when people argue like that, they end up quarreling/fighting with one another.
- because you know that it develops into quarrels.

for you know that it breeds quarreling: Paul said that when people argue about “foolish and ignorant” questions, the result is that they quarrel with those who believe differently than they do.

2 Timothy 2:24

Section 2:14–26: Timothy should be a workman who pleases God

Paragraph 2:22–26

In this paragraph, Paul instructed Timothy regarding how he could be a “container” that God can use.

2:24a

And a servant of the Lord must not be quarrelsome,

- Someone who works for the Lord must not quarrel.
- And you know that we^(incl) who serve the/our^(incl) Lord should not quarrel.

a servant of the Lord: The phrase a servant of the Lord is a general statement referring to all pastors and all teachers of Christian doctrine. Timothy was also a servant of the Lord, so Paul obviously intended it to apply to him also.

Paul made this general statement using the word servant in the singular. In some languages, it will be necessary to follow the example of the NLT and make servant plural.

The Lord’s servants must not quarrel

In many languages the form for general statements has a particular person and number marker or pronoun to indicate the subject of the verb. Some examples are:

We (incl) who are the Lord’s servants...

You (sing) who are the Lord’s servant... (See GNT, for example.)

Someone who is the Lord’s servant...

People who are the Lord’s servants...

You should use the pattern that is natural in your language and use consistent pronouns. In this context, the statements in 2:24–25 apply to Paul himself, to Timothy, and to anyone else who serves as a pastor or a leader for other Christians.

the Lord: Here the Lord refers to God.

2:24b

but must be kind to everyone,

- Instead, he must treat everyone well.
- Instead, we^(incl) should be gentle with all kinds of people.

but: The word but is a translation of the Greek conjunction *de*. Here Paul contrasts 2:24a with 2:24b. Some English versions translate this word as “instead.”

must be kind to everyone: In 2:24a, Paul told Timothy how the servant of the Lord must not act toward other people. In 2:24b, he told Timothy how the servant of the Lord should act toward everyone, including non-Christians, including those who want to argue with him. He did not say that Timothy should completely avoid people who did not believe the good news. He knew that if Timothy talked with them in a kind manner, he might be able to explain to them the truths that they needed to hear.

2:24c

able to teach,

- He must be able to communicate God’s truth,
- We should know how to explain clearly what the word of God says,

able to teach: A servant of the Lord must be able to teach. The teaching referred to here implies teaching the truth to both believers and non-believers. It also refers to teaching against false doctrine.

2:24d

and forbearing.

- and he must be patient with people.
- and we should be patient towards those who oppose us.

and forbearing: The Greek word that the BSB translates as forbearing means “to be patient” with those who oppose you. Many English versions translate this

word as “patient.” For example, the NLT says: “They must be...patient with difficult people.” It is recommended that you also translate this word as “patient.”

2 Timothy 2:25

Section 2:14–26: Timothy should be a workman who pleases God

Paragraph 2:22–26

In this paragraph, Paul instructed Timothy regarding how he could be a “container” that God can use.

2:25a

He must gently reprove those who oppose him,

- He must gently correct those who are against him,
- We^(incl) should tell/explain the true message in a kindly way to those who disagree with us.^(incl)

He must gently reprove: In the Greek this is literally “with gentleness instructing.” Because the phrase “with gentleness” is before the word “instructing,” it has special emphasis. Try to reflect that emphasis in your translation.

reprove: The word that the BSB translates as reprove also means “to correct.” Most English versions translate it as “correct.”

He ... him: The words He and him refers to someone/anyone who is “a servant of the Lord” in 2:24a.

2:25b

in the hope that God may grant them repentance

- so that maybe/perhaps God will allow them to repent
- If we^(incl) do this, it is possible that God will enable them to change their hearts/minds

in the hope that God may grant them repentance:

This is the first reason why the Lord’s servant should “gently reprove.” The second reason is in 2:26. Paul knew that if Timothy would be gentle with his opponents when he talked to them about the word of God, they might listen and realize that what they had believed was not true and that they need to change.

in the hope: The phrase in the hope is the translation of one Greek word that means “perhaps” or “maybe.” It is a word that indicates that Paul was not absolutely sure. It was possible that Timothy’s opponents would repent, but not certain.

that God may grant them: The meaning of the clause that God may grant them is “that God will make it possible for them,” “...enable them,” or “...allow them” to repent.

repentance: In this context repentance refers to a major change in what a person believes and how he behaves: That is, the person turns away from false teachings and now believes the true teachings of God. He turns away from sinful choices and now chooses to do things that please God.

As the phrase indicates, God is the one who makes repentance possible. A person cannot change himself in this way without God’s help.

2:25c

leading to a knowledge of the truth.

- and help/allow them to recognize what is true,
- and to know what are the true teachings about Christ.

leading to a knowledge of the truth: The literal translation of this phrase from the Greek is “into acknowledgement of the truth.” This grammatical construction makes it difficult to know how this phrase is connected to 2:25b. Most translations consider a knowledge of the truth to be the result of “repentance” in 2:25b. Therefore, they translate it:

perhaps God will allow them to repent and then come to know the truth

perhaps God will enable them to repent and will lead them to know the truth.

a knowledge of the truth: This phrase means “to know or recognize the true teachings.” (See the note on this phrase in Translator’s Notes for Titus 1:1d.)

2 Timothy 2:26

Section 2:14–26: Timothy should be a workman who pleases God

Paragraph 2:22–26

In this paragraph, Paul instructed Timothy regarding how he could be a “container” that God can use.

2:26a

Then they will come to their senses and escape the snare of the devil,

- and so that maybe/perhaps they may become clear again in their thinking and escape from the trap in which the devil has held them.
- The Lord’s servant should also gently instruct them so that maybe/perhaps these people will be able to think clearly again and escape from the devil’s deception that is like a trap.

- and so that they may come to their senses and escape from the control/power of the devil.

Then: The word Then introduces the second reason why Paul said that a servant of the Lord must “gently reprove” (2:25a).

He must gently reprove those who oppose him in the hope that

Reason 1: God may grant them repentance... (2:25b)

and in the hope that

Reason 2: they will come to their senses... (2:26a)

You should try to show how 2:26a is connected to 2:25b. Some English versions use the word “and” (NIV, RSV, NASB, NCV). Other versions make the connection more explicit with the word “Then” (BSB, NLT, GW). The GNT uses both words: “And then....”

It may be necessary to repeat the verb “will gently reprove” from 2:25a.

they will come to their senses and escape: This clause uses figurative language. It describes the next step a person who has believed wrong doctrine takes as he is restored to true faith.

The Greek text that the BSB translates as they will come to their senses and escape is a single verb in Greek. The verb literally means “to come to one’s senses,” or “to start thinking correctly again (after being deceived).” Scholars do not agree about whether to express this using two verbs or one:

1. Most English versions use two verbs and believe that the verb “escape” is implicit: People who oppose the true teachings of Christ are like people who have been deceived and can no longer think clearly, and they are like people who are caught in a trap. For example, GNT says,

And then they will come to their senses and escape.... See also BSB, NIV, NJB, NLT, GW, NET, REB, NASB.

1. Other English versions use a single verb. People who oppose the true teachings of Christ are like people who are caught in a trap. For example, the RSV says,

and they may escape.... See also CEV and KJV.

It is recommended that you follow option (1) and the majority of versions and use two verbs.

This is the only place in the New Testament where this verb occurs. To “come to one’s senses” is an idiom in English, so avoid translating it literally unless you have the same idiom in your language. If not, use a word or phrase that describes someone who recovers from being unable to think clearly.

escape the snare of the devil: The word escape is not in the Greek text, but it is clearly implied in the phrase. Paul was thinking about the way an animal gets caught in a trap and cannot get free. In a similar way, the devil has tricked the person into rejecting the truth and believing what is false. It is as though that person is an animal in a trap, but the trap is one that the devil has set. However, when a person “repents” (by accepting the truth of God’s word), he becomes free from the devil’s power. He is like an animal that has escaped from a trap and he can think clearly again and be able to recognize what is true and what is false.

If your language does not have a similar figure of speech, you can say something like:

...escape from the power/control of the devil.

devil: The devil is the chief of all evil spirits. The name of the devil is Satan. See devil in the Glossary.

2:26b

who has taken them captive to his will.

- He had captured/trapped them to make them do what he wanted them to do.
- The devil has deceived them to make them do what he wants.

taken them captive to his will: Satan’s purpose for capturing men and women is to make them do what he wants. Satan influences people to reject God’s true message and believe his false message.

General Comment on 2:25–26

In 2:26 Paul mentions two events, which the Greek lists in the following order: (a) people escape from Satan’s trap, and (b) Satan traps them. The BSB and most other English versions follow the Greek order, but the chronological order is the opposite. For that reason, in some languages it may be necessary to reorder the parts of the verse as follows:

^{26b}The devil has trapped people to make them obey him. ^{25a}We (incl) must gently correct these people who are against us ^{25b}so that perhaps God will enable them to change their hearts/thinking ^{25c}and to recognize what is true, ^{26a}and so that they may come to their senses and escape from the devil's trap.

2 Timothy 3:1

Section 3:1–9: Paul described the way people will behave in the last days

3:1a

But understand this:

- ¶ Pay attention to what I will say now.
- ¶ Timothy, I want you to know that

But: Paul used the Greek word *de* again to indicate he was changing to a new theme. Use the appropriate words or forms in your language that indicate a change in the topics being talked about.

understand this: The phrase that the BSB translates as *understand this* is literally “know this.” Other ways to translate this phrase are “mark this,” “remember this,” or “realize this.”

this: The word *this* refers to what follows.

3:1b

In the last days terrible times will come.

- The last days of this world will have terrible times.
- in the last/final age of this world there will be difficult times.

In the last days: In the New Testament, the phrase *In the last days* can refer to either:

1. the long period of time between Christ's first and second coming,
2. a shorter period of time just before Christ returns.

Here it probably refers to the long time period between the first and second comings of Christ. It is the last days in the sense that it is the final time period of this world. Paul implied that he and Timothy were already living in the last days.

The phrase *the last days* is used several times in the New Testament. See Acts 2:17, Hebrews 1:2, 2 Peter 3:3. If you have already translated these passages, refer to them as you translate.

terrible times will come: The phrase *terrible times* refers to difficult periods of time during the last days. The times will be terrible because people will behave as though there were no God. They will commit very

sinful acts. These times will be terrible for Christians and for the church.

In 3:2a–3:5b you will find a long list of examples of what Paul meant by the expression *terrible times*. Paul was not referring here to disasters such as wars, famines, and earthquakes.

terrible: The Greek word that the BSB translates as *terrible* could be translated as “difficult,” “hard to bear,” or “troublesome.”

2 Timothy 3:2

Section 3:1–9: Paul described the way people will behave in the last days

3:2–3:5b

In 3:2–3:5b, Paul lists several reasons why there will be terrible times. Paul used some of these words in Romans chapter 1.

3:2a

For men will be lovers of themselves,

- For people will love only themselves and not others.
- This is because people will only care about themselves.

For: This verse begins with the Greek conjunction *gar*, which can be translated as *For* or “because.” This conjunction introduces Paul's list of reasons why there will be terrible times. Use the appropriate conjunction or expression in your language to indicate such a relationship.

men will be lovers of themselves: This clause means that people will be selfish and overly concerned about themselves. They will ignore the needs of other people. They will love themselves, but not other people.

3:2b

lovers of money,

- They will love money,
- They will be greedy.

lovers of money: The phrase *lovers of money* is the BSB translation of one Greek word. Another way to translate this word is “greedy.”

3:2c

boastful, arrogant,

- will boast about themselves, will be arrogant,
- They will boast/talk about the great things that they do. They will think that they are better than other people are.

boastful, arrogant: These two terms have similar meanings.

boastful: People are boastful when they talk or brag about themselves in a proud way. This Greek word also occurs in Romans 1:30.

arrogant: People are arrogant when they think and feel that they are more important than other people are. Another English word for this term is “proud.” This Greek word also occurs in Romans 1:30.

3:2d abusive,

- be insulting,
- They will speak scornfully/disrespectfully to/about other people.

abusive: This term refers to the rude manner in which some people talk to, or talk about, other people. Some other English words for this term are “insulting” or “slandorous.” It refers to abusing people with words, not abusing them physically.

3:2e disobedient to their parents,

- will disobey their parents,
- They will refuse to obey their parents.

3:2f ungrateful,

- will be unthankful,
- They will not be grateful to those who help them.

ungrateful: People are ungrateful when they do not show appreciation to others who have helped them. Another English word for this term is “unthankful.” Many people do not recognize that ungratefulness is a sin, but it is one of the sins that Paul mentioned in Romans 1:21.

3:2g unholy,

- will be profane,
- They will not respect the things of God.

unholy: People are unholy when they do not respect or honor God or matters having to do with God. Some synonyms for this term are “irreligious,” “irreverent,” “profane,” or “wicked.” The Greek word that the BSB translates as unholy occurs only here and in 1 Timothy 1:9.

2 Timothy 3:3

Section 3:1–9: Paul described the way people will behave in the last days

3:3a unloving,

- these people will be without any love for others,

- They will not have any affection for other people.

unloving: In the last days, people will not have any love or affection even for those whom it is natural to love, such as the members of their own families. Other words for this term are “heartless,” or “unfeeling.” This Greek term also occurs in Romans 1:31.

3:3b unforgiving,

- and will not forgive others.
- They will refuse to resolve problems with other people.

unforgiving: This word refers to people who refuse to resolve problems between themselves and other people. They have chosen not to forgive people who have done something wrong to them.

3:3c slanderous,

- They will tell lies about other people.

slanderous: People are slanderous when they tell lies about other people and try to ruin their reputation. Paul used this same word in 1 Timothy 3:11.

3:3d without self-control,

- will not control themselves,
- They will not be able to control their desires.

without self-control: This phrase is the BSB’s translation of a single Greek word. It describes people who do not have the self-discipline to stop themselves from doing things they should not do, or to make themselves do the things they know they should do.

3:3e brutal,

- will be cruel/fierce,
- They will often hurt other people.

brutal: This word can also mean “untamed,” “savage,” “cruel,” or “fierce.” Paul used this word to describe cruel people who would not hesitate to hurt other people.

3:3f without love of good,

- they will not love what is good/righteous,
- They will hate what is good.

without love of good: The phrase without love of good is a literal translation of one Greek word. This word occurs only here in the New Testament, but its opposite occurs in Titus 1:8 where an overseer is to be “one who loves what is good.”

In some languages, a term like “haters” is more meaningful than a negative expression like “without love.” For example, the NCV has “They...will hate what is good.” Use the term that is more natural in your language.

good: This phrase refers to anything that is righteous, such as righteous actions.

2 Timothy 3:4

Section 3:1–9: Paul described the way people will behave in the last days

3:4a traitorous,

- they will be traitors,
- They will betray their friends to their enemies.

traitorous: The Greek word that the BSB translates as traitorous is the word that people used to refer to traitors, such as Judas Iscariot (Luke 6:16). People who are traitorous are traitors who pretend to be the friends of someone, but in reality they are his enemies. They betray that person to his enemies.

3:4b reckless,

- will be reckless.
- They will do foolish things without thinking about the consequences.

reckless: People are reckless when they act quickly and do whatever they want to do without stopping to think about the consequences of their action. Some other ways of expressing this are “rash,” “reckless in speech and action,” “foolhardy,” and “thoughtless.” The Greek word that the BSB translates as reckless occurs only here and in Acts 19:36.

3:4c conceited,

- They will think that they are more important than others are.

conceited: People are conceited when they think and behave as though they are superior to other people. They are very proud. In many languages, there is an idiomatic way to say this. GNT uses an English figure of speech and says “swollen with pride.” The Greek word “foolhardy,” translated here as conceited, also occurs in 1 Timothy 3:6 and 1 Timothy 6:4.

3:4d lovers of pleasure rather than lovers of God,

- They will love pleasure instead of loving God,

- They will love doing the evil things that they enjoy instead of loving God,

lovers of pleasure: In the Greek text, lovers of pleasure is one word composed of the word for “love” joined to the word for “pleasure.” This Greek word means that people will do only that which they like/enjoy doing.

rather than: The Greek word that the BSB translated as rather than can also mean “instead of.”

lovers of God: In Greek, lovers of God is one word composed of the word for “love” joined to the word for “God.”

The entire clause (3:4d) implies that some of the things that people enjoy doing offend God, and that when they do these things they are sinning against God.

2 Timothy 3:5

Section 3:1–9: Paul described the way people will behave in the last days

3:5a having a form of godliness

- they will practice a type of religion,
- they will appear to be godly,
- they will act as if they worship/serve God,

having a form of godliness: Here Paul described people who do many types of religious things: they use religious words and expressions, they participate in religious ceremonies, and they may even teach other people religious beliefs that sound like the truth. But all these things are external actions and words. Their hearts have not changed. It refers to people who practice a type/kind of religion, but not true Christianity. It has only the outward appearance of true faith.

form: The word form means “outward appearance.” This Greek word occurs only here and in Romans 2:20.

godliness: The Greek word that the BSB translates as godliness, means “the duty that man owes God to serve and worship him.” Some English versions translate this word by “religion.” (See RSV, GNT, NET, REB.)

3:5b but denying its power.

- but they deny that this religion has any power.
- (NLT:) but they will reject the power that could make them godly.
- but they will refuse to allow God’s power to change/correct their evil lives.

denying its power: The phrase denying its power means that people will refuse to allow God's power to make them genuinely godly.

denying: The word that the BSB translates as denying means "to refuse" or "to reject."

its: This word refers back to "godliness/religion" in 3:5a.

power: The word power refers to the power found in true Christianity. It is God's power that changes people's behavior and makes them holy.

3:5c

Turn away from such as these!

- Avoid those people!
- Do not associate with those types of people!

Turn away from such as these!: Here Paul commanded Timothy to "avoid" or "stay away from" people who have the characteristics he listed in 3:2-5.

2 Timothy 3:6

Section 3:1-9: Paul described the way people will behave in the last days

3:6a

They are the kind

- ¶ The reason you should avoid them is because some of these people

(RSV) For: Paul used the Greek conjunction *gar* at the beginning of 3:6 to connect 3:6 with 3:5. It is often translated "for" or "because." This conjunction indicates that Paul was about to tell Timothy the reason why he should "have nothing to do" with those people who appear to be religious but who are actually ungodly. For reasons of style, the BSB and some other English versions have left this word untranslated.

They are the kind: The Greek indicates that Paul was going to begin talking about some of the people in 3:2-5. GNT has "Some of them...." The RSV has "among them are those...."

These people seemed to be Christians, but they were not. They were false teachers who deceived people for their own gain and influenced them with their false teachings.

3:6b

who worm their way into households

- are deceiving/fooling others to get into their houses

who worm their way into households: The clause worm their way is an English idiom. You should not translate it literally.

The Greek word that the BSB translates as worm their way literally means "to creep into" or "to sneak into." In this context, it means that these false teachers deceived people to get invited into their homes. This word does not mean that they entered houses secretly without the inhabitants being aware that someone had entered.

households: This word refers to the people who live in the house. The false teachers tried to deceive individuals so that they would be welcomed into the rest of the family.

3:6c

and captivate vulnerable women

- and deceive foolish women who live there,
- Then when they enter those homes, they trick gullible women.

and captivate vulnerable women: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as captivate literally means "to take as a captive in war." Paul used it figuratively here, implying that the false teachers were "gain control over," "capturing the minds" or "deceiving" some of the women in order to have influence over them. In this context it does not imply that they used force or that they literally kept them as prisoners.

vulnerable women: The Greek noun that the BSB translates as vulnerable women literally means "little women." This particular form of the Greek word for "women" referred to the type of women who were immature in the way they thought about things. These women readily believed whatever the false teachers told them and would do whatever they asked them to do. Therefore other people did not respect them.

Other ways to translate this word are "weak-willed women," "unwise women" or "foolish women."

3:6d

who are weighed down with sins

- who are burdened by the guilt of their sins.
- These women have sinned so many times that it feels like they are carrying a burden.

who are weighed down with sins: The Greek word that the BSB translates as weighed down literally means "to heap" or "to pile up." This is figurative language meaning that these women had sinned so much that their sins were a "burden to them," or their many sins "troubled their minds." They felt very guilty about the many wrong things that they had done.

with sins: Paul did not describe the specific sins that these women had committed. The text uses the expression "by various passions" in 3:6e which suggests

that these women had probably sinned in several different ways.

3:6e

and led astray by various passions,

- They are being led by all kinds of evil desires/passions.
- All kinds of evil desires control them.

and led astray: The Greek word that the BSB translates as led astray is a passive verb. It means “to be swayed,” “to be guided,” or “to be controlled” by something.

by various passions: This implies that these women had committed several different types of sins.

2 Timothy 3:7

Section 3:1–9: Paul described the way people will behave in the last days

3:7a

who are always learning

- They are always learning new/different teachings

who are always learning: The phrase always learning indicates that these women often listened to people who taught about religion. Because they often sinned, they kept looking for something new and different. So they continued to listen to the false teachers to learn their new doctrines. GNT says: “always trying to learn.” This statement does not mean that these women were slow to learn in the sense that they were mentally dull or unintelligent.

3:7b

but never able to come to a knowledge of the truth.

- but they are never able to recognize/distinguish the truth.
- but they can never know/understand the true teaching/message about Christ.

but: Here the BSB has translated the Greek conjunction kai as but. Usually kai is translated as “and.” However, in this context it signals an unexpected result, so it may also be translated “but.” It is recommended that you follow the majority of modern English versions and translate the conjunction as “but.”

never able to come to a knowledge of the truth:

These women were not able to recognize the true teaching of the gospel. They had heard some of the truth, but it had been mixed with false ideas, and they were not able to recognize what was true from what was false.

to come to a knowledge of: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as to come to a knowledge of also means “to recognize” or “to distinguish.”

the truth: In this context the phrase the truth refers to the gospel.

2 Timothy 3:8

Section 3:1–9: Paul described the way people will behave in the last days

3:8a

Just as Jannes and Jambres opposed Moses,

- Long ago Jannes and Jambres opposed Moses.

Just as Jannes and Jambres: In 3:8, Paul returned to talking about the false teachers. He compared them to two men who opposed Moses.

Because these men lived long before Paul and Timothy, it may also be helpful to begin this verse with a time phrase such as “long ago....”

Jannes and Jambres: Jannes and Jambres are the names of the two magicians who performed false miracles in front of Moses and Pharaoh, the king of Egypt. Their names are not mentioned in the Old Testament, but they are known from Jewish tradition. (See Exodus 7:11–22 and Exodus 8:7–19.) These two magicians wanted to show Pharaoh that their power was as great as the power that Moses had from the true God.

In your translation, it may be helpful to add a footnote explaining briefly what Paul meant when he referred to Jannes and Jambres. For example:

These men were magicians who opposed Moses in Pharaoh’s court. (See Exodus 7:11–22.)

opposed Moses: The word opposed means “to be against” or “to resist.”

3:8b

so also these men oppose the truth.

- In the same way, these men/teachers oppose the truth.
- So also these false teachers are against the true teaching/message about Christ.

so also these men: Here these men refers to the false teachers that Paul mentioned in 3:6a.

oppose the truth: These men opposed the truth by teaching false doctrines, so that people would not hear or pay attention to the true message about Jesus

Christ. Another way to express this idea is “these men hinder/prevent others from hearing the truth.”

the truth: The phrase the truth refers to the gospel.

General Comment on 3:8a–b

In some languages, it may be more natural to reverse the order of the comparison. Here is an example:

These teachers oppose the truth just as Jannes and Jambres opposed Moses.

3:8c

They are depraved in mind

- They have corrupt minds,
- They think about wicked things,

In 3:8c Paul was further describing the “men” in 3:8b. The BSB indicates this by beginning a new sentence.

They are depraved in mind: In 3:8c–d, Paul used two phrases to describe the men who opposed the gospel. This is the first description.

depraved: The Greek word that the BSB translates as depraved also means “corrupt” or “ruined.” Paul used a form of this Greek word in 1 Timothy 6:5.

3:8d

and disqualified from the faith.

- and they are worthless in matters regarding the faith.
- and they are failures concerning the teachings that we believe.

and disqualified from the faith: This statement is the second description of those men who opposed the truth.

disqualified: The Greek word that the BSB translates as disqualified means “not passing the test,” “failed,” “rejected,” “worthless,” or “unfit.” It is the opposite of the word “approved” in 2:15a. GNT says: “who are failures in the faith.”

The word disqualified refers back to the word “men” in 3:8c, not the word “faith.” So this word means “disqualified men” or “worthless men.”

from the faith: This phrase in Greek literally means “concerning the faith.” These men may have been useful to their community in other ways, but they were worthless concerning the Christian faith.

the faith: In this context the faith refers to the teachings or doctrines of the Christian religion and the standards of right and wrong that are associated with it. See faith in the Glossary, Meaning 2.

2 Timothy 3:9

Section 3:1–9: Paul described the way people will behave in the last days

3:9a

But they will not advance much further.

- They will only be able to accomplish their purpose for a short time,
- But they will not be able to deceive people for very long,

But they will not advance much further: The BSB phrase not advance much further is a figure of speech in English. Other versions have translated this as:

they will not make much progress (NRSV)

Their successes will be short-lived (REB)

they will not be successful (NCV)

Here, Paul meant that the false teachers would not be able to deceive people indefinitely. Although they might deceive them for a short period of time, eventually people would realize that the “religion” they taught and practiced did not come from God. After a while, many people would stop following them.

3:9b

For just like Jannes and Jambres, their folly will be plain to everyone.

- because, just as people long ago recognized that Jannes and Jambres were foolish, everyone will recognize that they are foolish.
- because everyone will clearly see their foolishness. This is what happened to those men Jannes and Jambres.

For just like Jannes and Jambres, their folly will be plain to everyone:

This part of the verse gives a reason why the false teachers “will not advance much further.” The BSB reordered the phrases in this verse. In Greek, the phrase just like Jannes and Jambres is at the end of the sentence. In some languages it may be helpful to follow the word order of the Greek, as RSV and GNT have done. See also the second Meaning Line of 3:9b in the Display.

folly: The Greek word that the BSB translates as folly means “stupidity.”

2 Timothy 3:10

Section 3:10–4:8: Paul gave Timothy some more instructions and encouraged him to continue preaching the gospel

In 3:10–4:8 Paul reminded Timothy that Timothy had thoroughly learned true doctrine, so he should continue to preach it faithfully, even if he had to suffer because of it.

3:10a

You, however, have observed my teaching,

- ¶ But as for you, Timothy, you know very well what I teach people.

You, however: This verse in Greek begins with the pronoun meaning “you (sing)” and the conjunction *de*, which the BSB translates as *however*. By using the pronoun as the very first word, Paul clearly contrasts Timothy with the false teachers of 3:1–9. Use the words or grammatical pattern in your language that also show such contrast. For example, you could say: “But as for you....”

In addition, since this verse begins a new section, it might be helpful for the readers if you repeat Timothy’s name. You might say, “But as for you, Timothy....”

have observed: The clause *have observed* is the BSB translation of one Greek verb. Some English versions have translated this verb literally as “follow.” (See GNT, NET, NASB, NCV, NJB.) Other versions have translated this verb metaphorically as “know” in the sense of “follow with the mind.” (See the NIV, KJV, GW, NLT, CEV, JBP.) Paul used this same verb in 1 Timothy 4:6.

It is important for you to notice that this one verb relates to all nine items that Paul listed in 3:10a–3:11a. In Greek, the verb occurs only once, but in many languages, it is necessary to repeat the verb at some point or to use a different verb before some of the things that Paul listed. Two English versions (GNT, NCV) that translate the Greek verb as “follow” in 3:10a change the verb to “observe” or “know” when they repeat a verb later in the list.

In translating this verb, you have at least the following two choices:

- Follow the example of the BSB and begin the list with a verb that can be used with all of the items in the list. The BSB uses “have observed.”
- Follow the example of the NCV and use one verb for part of the list and another verb for the rest of the list, when it becomes necessary. The NCV uses “follow” and “know.”

my teaching: When Paul said *my teaching* he was referring to all of the doctrines that he had taught. He considered all of these doctrines to be closely related to each other and spoke of them as a group.

my: In the Greek text this pronoun occurs just once before this first item in the list of things that Timothy knew about Paul’s life and teaching. In that position it indicates that *my* applies to each item in the list from 3:10a–11a. The BSB repeats the word *my* for each item in the list, but you should follow the patterns for proper pronoun use in your language as you translate each of the items in 3:10b–11a. You must not feel that you have to follow the Greek or any English grammatical pattern.

3:10b–11a

In 3:10b–11a, Paul listed some of the things that characterized the way that he had served Christ. He reminded Timothy about some things that Timothy already knew about Paul and how he had served the Lord and suffered because he preached the gospel. Paul implied that he hoped Timothy would remember these characteristics and imitate them. In some languages, it may be necessary to use verbs or whole sentences to translate each of the abstract nouns that Paul used in 3:10b–11a.

3:10b

my conduct,

- You know the way I live.

my conduct: The phrase *my conduct* is the translation of one Greek word. It indicates that Timothy knew that Paul had lived in a way that was right according to God’s word. He also knew that Paul behaved in the same righteous manner that he instructed the believers to follow.

3:10c

my purpose,

- You know what my purpose/plan is.
- You know what I want/try to do.

my purpose: The Greek word that the BSB translates as *purpose* also occurs in 1:9d. Some other ways to translate this word are “plan,” “intention,” “goal,” or “what I want to do.”

Paul’s purpose in life was to preach God’s word to others. When groups of Christians formed congregations as a result of his preaching, it was also Paul’s purpose to teach them even more truths from the word of God, so that they would develop spiritually.

3:10d

my faith,

- You know that I trust/believe God.

faith: In Paul's letters, the Greek word that the BSB translates as faith has at least three meanings:

1. a Christian's belief or trust in God,
2. the basic doctrines that Christians believe,
3. faithfulness or trustworthiness.

In this verse, Paul probably used the word faith in the first sense. Here Paul said that Timothy knew how much he (Paul) trusted God. See faith in the Glossary, Meaning 1.

See the note in 3:10a about the word "my."

3:10e

my patience, my love,

- You know that I have been patient with all kinds of people, and that I have loved all kinds of people.

patience: The word patience refers to being able to endure something that is unpleasant without complaining. Here Paul was referring to his own patience towards other people as he traveled to different places preaching and teaching the good news.

love: Here Paul was referring to his love for other people, not his love for God. Paul did not define love as an emotional feeling. He defined it as an attitude of caring about the well-being of other people.

3:10f

my perseverance,

- You know that I have endured difficulties
- You know that I persist/continue in doing my work

perseverance: This word means almost the same thing as the word "patience" in 3:10e. The word perseverance refers to being able to continue doing whatever one is doing, even in difficult circumstances. Timothy knew about Paul's perseverance because he knew that Paul had continued to preach and teach even when he was living in difficult circumstances and when people were reluctant to accept his teaching.

2 Timothy 3:11

Section 3:10–4:8: Paul gave Timothy some more instructions and encouraged him to continue preaching the gospel

In 3:10–4:8 Paul reminded Timothy that Timothy had thoroughly learned true doctrine, so he should continue to preach it faithfully, even if he had to suffer because of it.

3:11a

my persecutions, and the sufferings

- You know that people have abused/persecuted me and caused me pain.

persecutions: The word persecutions refers to physical or mental abuse or harassment. People who did not agree with Paul's religious beliefs had regularly said and done things to discredit or harm him. They did those things so he would stop preaching about Christ.

sufferings: The word sufferings refers to the physical pain that Paul had experienced because people persecuted him.

3:11b

that came upon me in Antioch, Iconium, and Lystra.

- You know about the awful kinds of things that happened to me in Antioch, Iconium, and Lystra.
- You know about the terrible kinds of things that people did to me in the towns of Antioch, Iconium, and Lystra.

that came upon me in Antioch, Iconium, and Lystra:

Here Paul named some specific places where his "persecutions and sufferings" had occurred.

Antioch, Iconium, and Lystra: These are the names of three towns. Before translating this verse read what Luke wrote about Paul's visits to these towns, in Acts 13:44–14:23. Lystra was the town where the Jews provoked the crowd to stone Paul. It was also the town where Timothy and his parents lived. So even though Paul did not specifically mention "stoning," Timothy knew what Paul meant when he said that came upon me.

3:11c

What persecutions I endured!

- You know that I endured repeated persecution there
- You know that people there persecuted me many times

What persecutions I endured!: There was no punctuation in the original Greek manuscripts of the New Testament. Therefore Bible scholars have different opinions about how this clause relates to the rest of the sentence and what its function is. The main interpretations are:

1. It restates the previous clause (3:11b) about what had happened to Paul in Antioch, Iconium, and Lystra. For example, the NJB says:

^{11a}and the persecutions and sufferings ^{11b}that came to me in places like Antioch, Iconium and Lystra—^{11c}all the persecutions I have endured: See also NIV, RSV, GNT, NASB, REB, KJV.

1. It is the first clause of the following sentence. For example, the NET says:

^{11a}as well as the persecutions and sufferings
^{11b}that happened to me in Antioch, in Iconium, and
 in Lystra. ^{11c}I endured these persecutions ^{11d}and
 the Lord delivered me from them all. See also GW,
 NCV, NLT, LSA.

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1) as do the majority of translations.

3:11d

Yet the Lord rescued me from all of them.

- But the Lord Jesus rescued me from all of the persecutions.
- But the Lord Jesus delivered me from all these difficult situations.

Yet the Lord rescued me from all of them: There were times when the people who persecuted Paul almost killed him. But the Lord had protected and rescued him from each of these difficult situations.

Yet: The Greek conjunction *kai*, which the BSB translates here as Yet, is the most common way to join sentences in Greek. Its most basic meaning is “and.” Here, 3:11d seems to be in contrast with 3:11c. So an English conjunction like “but” shows contrast much better than “and.” GNT, KJV, NLT, and NCV all translate this word as “but.”

the Lord: Here the word Lord most likely refers to Jesus, not God the Father.

If there is a term in your language for Lord that can refer to both God the Father and to Jesus, use it. If not, use a word that specifically refers to Jesus, for example, “the Lord Jesus.”

them: The pronoun them refers to the persecutions in 3:11c.

2 Timothy 3:12

Section 3:10–4:8: Paul gave Timothy some more instructions and encouraged him to continue preaching the gospel

In 3:10–4:8 Paul reminded Timothy that Timothy had thoroughly learned true doctrine, so he should continue to preach it faithfully, even if he had to suffer because of it.

3:12a

Indeed, all who desire to live godly lives in Christ Jesus

- In fact, all people who want to behave in a way that pleases God and who believe in Christ Jesus
- Every person who wants to do what pleases God and who has faith in Christ Jesus

Indeed: The phrase Indeed is how the BSB translates the two Greek conjunctions *de* and *kai* which occur together here. Paul had more to say about persecution. After reminding Timothy that he had suffered for the Lord, he used these words to introduce a general statement about suffering.

You have at least two options for translating these Greek words here:

- Choose a conjunction or grammatical feature in your language that would indicate that Paul was introducing a general statement. Another phrase in English similar to Indeed is “in fact.”
- Leave the words untranslated, as do the GNT, REB, CEV, and NCV.

godly lives: The Greek word that the BSB translates as godly also means “devout,” “pious,” or “religious.” All who live godly lives are those who submit themselves to God and act in ways that please God. Some ways to translate godly lives are: “live/act in a way that pleases God” or “do that which pleases God.”

in Christ Jesus: The phrase in Christ Jesus refers to those who “believe in Christ Jesus.” This phrase further defines the group of people who will be persecuted (3:12b). Those who will be persecuted are those who want to live a godly life and who believe in Christ Jesus.

Christ Jesus: Notice that in this verse Paul referred to Jesus as Christ Jesus instead of “Jesus Christ.” The names Christ Jesus and “Jesus Christ” mean the same thing. In most English translations and other national language translations, “Jesus Christ” and “Christ Jesus” are translated literally and in the same order as they occur in the Greek manuscripts. It is recommended that you do the same thing. However, if the people who will be reading your translation might be confused when they see two different word orders of the names, you may decide to translate Christ Jesus as “Jesus Christ,” which is the more familiar word order.

3:12b

will be persecuted,

- will be persecuted by unbelievers.
- will encounter people who will persecute him.

will be persecuted: The Greek verb is passive, as the BSB shows. If you need to make the verb active, you can say something similar to this:

Indeed, people will persecute everyone who desires to live a godly life....

If you use an active verb, be sure that the emphasis remains on the word “everyone,” not on the clause “people will persecute.” The second Meaning Line in the Display gives another example of how you can change the passive verb into an active one.

2 Timothy 3:13

Section 3:10–4:8: Paul gave Timothy some more instructions and encouraged him to continue preaching the gospel

In 3:10–4:8 Paul reminded Timothy that Timothy had thoroughly learned true doctrine, so he should continue to preach it faithfully, even if he had to suffer because of it.

3:13a

while evil men and imposters go from bad to worse,

- But wicked people and deceivers will become worse and worse.
- But wicked men and those who pretend to be who they are not are doing evil acts now, and they will do things that are even more evil

while: The Greek word that the BSB translates as while is the common Greek conjunction *de*. Most scholars and English versions interpret this word as indicating a contrast between the godly people in 3:12 and the evil people in 3:13.

evil men and imposters: The two terms evil men and imposters refer back to the false teachers. Scholars disagree about how these terms are related. The interpretations are:

1. These two terms describe two separate groups of people. For example, the NLT says:

But evil people and imposters will flourish. See also BSB, NIV, GNT, RSV, NASB, REB, KJV, GW, NET.

1. These two terms refer to the same group of people: the evil men are also imposters. So these two nouns express a single idea. For example, the CEV says:

evil people who pretend to be what they are not
See also NJB and NCV.

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1).

imposters: An impostor is a person who pretends to be someone that he is not in order to deceive other people. A synonym for this term is “deceivers.”

go from bad to worse: Paul did not specify in what way these men would continually become worse. He probably was referring to their moral lives and to their teaching. Make the translation of this portion of the verse as general as possible.

3:13b

deceiving and being deceived.

- They deceive people, and they themselves will be deceived by others.
- as they mislead people, and other people deceive them.

deceiving: The Greek word that the BSB translates as deceiving also means “misleading.” The implied object for the verb deceiving is “other people.”

and being deceived: The text does not say who deceives the evil men and imposters. It is probably “other people,” but would not be the same group of people that they deceived.

2 Timothy 3:14

Section 3:10–4:8: Paul gave Timothy some more instructions and encouraged him to continue preaching the gospel

In 3:10–4:8 Paul reminded Timothy that Timothy had thoroughly learned true doctrine, so he should continue to preach it faithfully, even if he had to suffer because of it.

3:14a

But as for you, continue in the things you have learned

- But as for you, continue to believe the things/truths that you have learned
- You, however, Timothy, should continue to believe what we^(excl) have taught you.

But as for you: The two Greek words that occur at the beginning of this verse also occurred at the beginning of 3:10a. The literal translation of these words is “but you (sing).” In this context, they clearly contrast Timothy with the evil men and imposters mentioned in 3:13. If your language has a term to indicate a strong contrast, you should use it here.

continue in the things you have learned: This phrase means “continue to believe what you have learned.”

If it is necessary to specify from whom Timothy learned the gospel, you can say “things you have learned from us.” The pronoun should be plural because in Greek, the phrase “from whom” in 3:14c is plural. Timothy learned the gospel from his mother, grandmother, and Paul.

3:14b and firmly believed,

- and that you are confident/sure are true,
- Continue to believe/trust in that which you are certain is true,

and firmly believed: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as firmly believed also means “have believed to be true.”

3:14c since you know from whom you have learned them.

- because you know that those from whom you learned them are trustworthy,
- because you know and can trust us^(excl) who taught these things/truths to you.

since you know: Implied in the clause you know is “and you can trust” those people who taught the truth about God to you.

from whom you have learned them: The phrase from whom refers to Timothy’s mother, grandmother, and Paul.

them: There is no pronoun here in the Greek text, but it is implied. If in 3:14a you have chosen the word “things,” “truths,” or “teachings” to represent the word “the things” (BSB), you should follow English versions, such as the NASB and REB, and use the plural pronoun “them” here. Or you can repeat the word “things,” “truths,” or “teachings” if it is more natural in your language.

General Comment on 3:14

In some languages, it may be more natural to reorder the parts of this verse as follows:

^{14c}You know and can trust those from whom you learned the gospel. ^{14a}So continue to believe what you have learned ^{14b}and have been convinced is true.

^{14c}You know those who have taught you the gospel. ^{14a}So continue to follow what they taught you. ^{14b}Continue to believe it.

2 Timothy 3:15

Section 3:10–4:8: Paul gave Timothy some more instructions and encouraged him to continue preaching the gospel

In 3:10–4:8 Paul reminded Timothy that Timothy had thoroughly learned true doctrine, so he should con-

tinue to preach it faithfully, even if he had to suffer because of it.

3:15a From infancy you have known the Holy Scriptures,

- and you know that from the time you were a young child you have known the holy Scriptures.
- Ever since you were a small child, you have learned God’s word

From infancy you have known the Holy Scriptures: This clause is the second object of the verb “know” in 3:14c.

^{14c}You know those from whom you have learned these things/truths

^{15a}and you know that from infancy you have known the holy Scriptures

infancy: In this verse the term infancy refers to the time from which Timothy was able to learn. Timothy probably began learning the Scriptures when he was three to five years old. It does not literally mean from the time he was born. Another way to say this is “from the time you were a small child.”

known: Timothy knew the holy Scriptures because his mother and grandmother taught him the Scriptures. Another way to say this is that Timothy had “learned” the holy Scriptures.

Holy Scriptures: The Greek word that the BSB translates as Scriptures is literally “writings.” There were many “writings” in that day, so the word Holy specified that these “writings” were the “sacred writings” or the books of the Bible that we now call the Old Testament. Other ways to translate Holy Scriptures are “holy/sacred writings” or “God’s word.”

See holy in the Glossary, Meaning 2.

3:15b which are able to make you wise for salvation through faith in Christ Jesus.

- The holy Scriptures are able to cause you to understand that God saves you because you believe in Christ Jesus.
- which helps you to understand that God saves you when you believe in Christ Jesus.

which are able to make you wise: Paul said that learning the truths of the Scriptures will make a person wise.

Some other ways to say this are:

God's word is able to cause you to understand that...

As you learn God's word you become wise.

for salvation through faith in Christ Jesus: These words explain what a person will learn from God's word. Each person will be able to understand, as Timothy had done, what Christ Jesus did to make a way for God to save that person.

This complicated set of phrases can be analyzed as follows:

salvation = God saves you faith in Christ Jesus = you believe/trust in Christ Jesus

Simply stated, this means:

God saves you through your believing in Christ Jesus.

See salvation in the Glossary. See also faith in the Glossary, Meaning 1.

2 Timothy 3:16

Section 3:10–4:8: Paul gave Timothy some more instructions and encouraged him to continue preaching the gospel

In 3:10–4:8 Paul reminded Timothy that Timothy had thoroughly learned true doctrine, so he should continue to preach it faithfully, even if he had to suffer because of it.

3:16a

All Scripture is God-breathed

- All Scripture comes from God,
- All Scripture is words that God placed into the minds/thoughts of those who wrote them.

All Scripture is God-breathed: The term God-breathed is a literal translation of the Greek word that older English versions translated as “inspired.” This is the only place in the New Testament that this word is used.

This word indicates that the people who wrote the books of the Bible did not merely write what they themselves were thinking. It means that they wrote the thoughts that God put into their minds. God was the source or origin of what they wrote.

Another way to translate this term is “all Scripture came from God.” Whichever way you translate this term, be sure that the word “Scripture” is the topic of the sentence.

3:16b and is useful

- and it is beneficial/helpful to us^(incl)
- We^(incl) can use Scripture

is useful: The Greek word that the BSB translates as useful also means “helpful” or “beneficial.” This same word is used in 1 Timothy 4:8 and Titus 3:8.

In some languages, it may be necessary to say for whom Scripture is useful. Since Paul was writing to Timothy, he meant that Scripture was useful for Timothy and other church leaders as they would teach, correct, and instruct. If you must state the participants, use a general statement like “it is useful to us (incl).”

General Comment on 3:16a–b

There are two ways to interpret and translate 3:16a–b. They are:

1. “All Scripture is God-breathed and is useful....” This is the interpretation presented above. For example, GNT says:

All Scripture is inspired by God and is useful for teaching.... See also BSB, NIV, RSV, NET, NASB, KJV, NJB, GW, NLT, CEV, JBP, NCV.

1. “All God-breathed Scripture is useful....” This second interpretation is based on the fact that there is no word in the Greek text between “Scripture” and “God-breathed.” The REB says:

All inspired scripture has its use for teaching.... See also the footnotes in GNT, NRSV, NET.

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). Also, if the major language version in use in your area has a footnote here to show interpretation (2), it is recommended that you also include a footnote about it.

3:16c

for instruction,

- for teaching people,
- to teach people God's message/truth,

for instruction: Paul said that Timothy should use Scripture to teach people. If you need to indicate what the Scriptures teach and to whom it is taught. You could say:

All Scripture...is useful for teaching people God's message...

All Scripture...is useful for teaching people the truth....

3:16d for conviction,

- for rebuking/reprimanding them,
- to tell people that what they have done is wrong,

for conviction: The Greek word that the BSB translates as conviction means “to tell people that what they are believing or doing is wrong.” When Paul used this word, he was probably thinking of the false teachers who believed and taught false doctrine. Another way to translate this word in English is “rebuke” or “reprimand.” This Greek word occurs only here and as a verb in 4:2c (translated as “reprove”) and in 1 Timothy 5:20 (translated as “rebuked”).

3:16e for correction,

- for correcting errors/faults,
- to correct people when they do something that is wrong,

correction: The Greek word that the BSB translates as correction probably refers to correcting both wrong beliefs that people had and the wrong ways that they were behaving, and then showing them what was right. It is best to use a general term like GNT does, for example, “correcting faults.”

3:16f and for training in righteousness,

- and for training people to do what is right,
- and to teach/instruct them how to live a moral life.

for training in righteousness: Paul told Timothy that he should use the Scriptures to train, or instruct, people in righteousness.

righteousness: The word righteousness includes the meaning of “doing what God says is right/moral,” or “behaving correctly/morally.” So training in righteousness means, “to instruct people how to do what is right.” See righteousness in the Glossary, Meaning 1.

2 Timothy 3:17

Section 3:10–4:8: Paul gave Timothy some more instructions and encouraged him to continue preaching the gospel

In 3:10–4:8 Paul reminded Timothy that Timothy had thoroughly learned true doctrine, so he should continue to preach it faithfully, even if he had to suffer because of it.

3:17a so that the man of God

- so that the person who belongs to God
- Scripture is useful to us for all of this, so that a person who serves God

so that: The Greek conjunction *hina*, which the BSB translates as so that, connects 3:17 with 3:16. It indicates the purpose for which Scripture is useful (3:16), that is, so that the man of God may be able to do good works (3:17).

the man of God: This is a general expression, as is the phrase “a servant of the Lord” in 2:24a. It is not referring to a specific man, but to any person who serves God or belongs to him.

Some ways you could translate this phrase are “a person who serves God” or “each of God’s people.”

man: The Greek noun that the BSB translates as man actually refers to a human being, male or female. Avoid using a word that would make people think that this refers only to men.

3:17b may be complete, fully equipped for every good work.

- may be prepared and equipped to do every kind of good act.
- will be ready and able to do all kinds of good deeds.

may be complete, fully equipped: The two Greek words that the BSB translates as complete, fully equipped have the same root and almost the same meaning. They mean, “ready,” “prepared,” or “capable.” The fact that there are two such Greek words in this sentence makes the statement emphatic. There are two ways of translating this:

- Translate them as two separate words with similar meanings as in the BSB. As another example, the NET says:

that the person dedicated to God may be capable and equipped for every good work.

- Translate them as a single concept that includes an intensifier. For example, the NIV says:

so that the man of God may be thoroughly equipped....

If possible, you should follow the first option. If you do not have two related words, you can follow the exam-

ple of the NIV and translate one adjective modified by an intensifier to show emphasize this idea.

General Comment on 3:16–17

In Greek, 3:16 and 3:17 are one long sentence. In some languages it may be necessary to begin a new sentence at 3:17, as some modern English translations do. One way to do this is to repeat the subject of the sentence (Scripture) as follows: “Scripture is useful to you for all of this so that....” See the second Meaning Line of 3:17a in the Display.

2 Timothy 4:1

Section 3:10–4:8: Paul gave Timothy some more instructions and encouraged him to continue preaching the gospel

In 3:10–4:8 Paul reminded Timothy that Timothy had thoroughly learned true doctrine, so he should continue to preach it faithfully, even if he had to suffer because of it.

4:1

4:1 is an oath/solemn promise. Normally, Paul used oaths when he wanted to emphasize that what he was saying was true. For example, in Galatians 1:20, Paul wrote, “I assure you before God that what I am writing you is no lie.”

Here, however, Paul used an oath to emphasize the commands that follow in 4:2. Paul used also this same type of oath in 1 Timothy 5:21.

In Greek, this verse begins with a verb that means, “to solemnly urge,” or “to command.” The sentence then continues, naming God and Christ Jesus as the authorities before whom Paul gave Timothy the command that follows in 4:2. The BSB follows the order of the Greek clauses throughout this verse.

4:1a

I charge you

- ¶ I command you Timothy

I charge you: The phrase I charge you is the translation of one Greek word. It means, “I command you.” In the Greek text, this verb is the first word in the sentence, which emphasizes it.

4:1b

in the presence of God and of Christ Jesus,

- before God and Christ Jesus,
- with God and Christ Jesus as my witnesses,

in the presence of God and of Christ Jesus: When someone makes an oath, he usually calls on the name someone who has greater authority than he does.

Here Paul used the names of both God and Jesus to show how important the oath was.

Some ways to translate this phrase are:

before God and Christ Jesus

with God and Christ Jesus as my witnesses

Or you could use an appropriate oath formula in your language.

4:1c

who will judge the living and the dead,

- the judge of the living and the dead
- he/Jesus who will judge those who will be still alive and those who have died

who will judge the living and the dead: Paul used this clause to further strengthen his oath.

When Jesus Christ returns to the earth, he will judge both those who are still living and those who have already died. He will determine whether each person is innocent or guilty of breaking God’s law and what their reward or punishment will be.

the living: This refers to those people who will be alive at the time when Christ returns.

and the dead: This refers to those people who have died before Christ returns.

4:1d

and in view of His appearing and His kingdom:

- and because of his coming/returning to the earth and because of his kingdom,
- and because he will return and become king of everyone,
- when he appears to rule over the people of this world,

and in view of His appearing and His kingdom: Paul used this entire phrase to further emphasize his oath. The phrase in view of is the BSB translation of a Greek grammatical form that people used when they made an oath. Some English versions say “by his appearing and his kingdom.” You should choose a word or phrase in your language that people use when they make an oath.

His appearing: The phrase His appearing refers to the time when Christ will return to the earth and be visible to everyone.

and His kingdom: The phrase His kingdom refers to the time when Christ will rule all the people in the world.

General Comment on 4:1

In some languages, it may be better to end the oath with the clause in which Paul gives Timothy a charge as the NIV has done:

In the presence of God and of Christ Jesus, who will judge the living and the dead, and in view of his appearing and his kingdom, I give you this charge:

2 Timothy 4:2**Section 3:10–4:8: Paul gave Timothy some more instructions and encouraged him to continue preaching the gospel**

In 3:10–4:8 Paul reminded Timothy that Timothy had thoroughly learned true doctrine, so he should continue to preach it faithfully, even if he had to suffer because of it.

4:2a**Preach the word;**

- to preach the word of God.
- to preach the gospel.

Preach the word: The word refers to the gospel. Paul had already mentioned the “word” in 2:9c (“the word of God”) and 2:15c (“the word of truth”). Here, Paul commanded Timothy to proclaim publicly that good news from God and the truthful things it teaches.

4:2b**be prepared in season and out of season;**

- Be ready/prepared to preach the word of God when the circumstances are good/convenient and when they are not good.
- Be ready to preach it when people want to hear it and when they do not want to hear it.

be prepared: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as be prepared can have two meanings.

1. It means to be prepared or ready to preach the word of God. For example, GW says,

Be ready to spread the word.... See BSB, NIV, NASB, NCV, LSA.

1. It means to be insistent on or persistent in preaching the word of God. Timothy must not let anything stop him. For example, the NET says,

preach the message, be persistent.... See RSV, GNT, NJB, REB, NLT, KJV.

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). However, if many people in your area use a version in the national language that follows interpretation (2), you should use interpretation (2) or at least mention it in a footnote.

in season and out of season: This means that Timothy had to be ready to preach God’s word at all times, both when it seemed convenient/favorable to preach and also when it did not seem convenient.

Some languages may need to say to whom or for whom the time was convenient. These languages will need to indicate whether in season and out of season refers to:

1. whether people wanted to hear the gospel or not,
2. whether Timothy felt like preaching the gospel or not

If possible, translate in season and out of season without specifying to/for whom the preaching would be convenient. If you must make a choice, choose (1) above.

4:2c**reprove,**

- Correct people when they believe or do something that is wrong
- Tell people when their beliefs/actions are wrong

reprove: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as reprove means “to tell people when they have believed or done something wrong.” It also means to expose or point out faulty doctrine, beliefs, and actions. Another way to translate this word in English is “correct” or “reprimand.” This same verb occurs in 3:16d where the BSB translates it as “conviction”, and in 1 Timothy 5:20 (translated as “rebuked”).

4:2d**rebuke,**

- and strongly tell them to stop doing what is wrong/evil.
- and tell them to stop doing it.

rebuke: Paul also instructed Timothy to rebuke people who are sinning. This verb has a similar meaning to “reprove” in 4:2c but it is more specific and emphatic. It means, “to strongly tell people who are doing wrong to stop doing it.” Trench, Synonyms.

4:2e**and encourage**

- Encourage/urge them to continue doing what is right/good.
- Encourage the people who are doing what is right/good to continue.

encourage: Paul also told Timothy to encourage those people who knew the truth and who lived in ways that pleased God. Paul wanted Timothy to urge believers like that to continue to believe all that they had learned concerning the gospel and to continue to please God in everything that they did.

4:2f

with every form of patient instruction.

- Do all these things very patiently and by teaching them the word of God.

(NIV) with great patience: Scholars connect the phrase with great patience to the other parts of 4:2 in several ways. The two main views are:

1. It is connected to the preceding verbs “reprove,” “rebuke,” and “encourage.” For example, the NLT says:

Patiently correct, rebuke, and encourage your people with good teaching. See also NIV, NCV, NET, NASB.

1. It is connected to the following word “instruction.” For example, GW says:

Be very patient when you teach. See also BSB, GNT, CEV, REB.

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1).

instruction: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as instruction is literally “teaching.” Paul was telling Timothy that teaching was the method he was to use to reprove, rebuke, and encourage people.

2 Timothy 4:3

Section 3:10–4:8: Paul gave Timothy some more instructions and encouraged him to continue preaching the gospel

In 3:10–4:8 Paul reminded Timothy that Timothy had thoroughly learned true doctrine, so he should continue to preach it faithfully, even if he had to suffer because of it.

4:3a

For the time will come when men will not tolerate sound doctrine,

- For a day/time will come when people will not want to listen to true/correct teaching.
- You must do this now, because in the future, people will not accept true teaching.

For: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as For indicates that 4:3–4 gives a reason why Timothy was to do all the things that Paul asked him to do in 4:2.

the time will come: The phrase the BSB has used, the time will come, is an idiom in English. Other ways to say this are:

there will be a time...

in the future....

men: This refers to “people,” not just to men.

tolerate: The Greek word that the BSB translates as tolerate means “listen to,” or “accept.”

sound doctrine: The term sound doctrine refers to the teachings that the apostles accepted as being the correct way to understand God’s word, especially as it related to Christ.

4:3b-c

but with itching ears they will gather around themselves teachers

- Instead, because they are curious to hear unusual/exciting things, they will have/collect many teachers, who will tell them
- They will surround themselves with many different teachers who will tell them what pleases/satisfies their ears.
- They will listen to a great number of false teachers who will tell them what they want to hear.

4:3b

There is some implied information here. The implied information is “people should accept and live according to sound doctrine.”

but: The Greek conjunction *alla*, which the BSB translates as but, indicates a strong contrast. People should accept sound doctrine and live according that true understanding of God’s word, but instead, they follow their own desires.

with itching ears: The phrase itching ears is a figurative way of saying that people will have a curiosity to hear something sensational or exciting, even if it is not true. They want to hear what sounds good to them. They do not want to hear anyone who criticizes them for sinning.

4:3c

they will gather around themselves teachers: The Greek word that the BSB translates as gather around also means “to accumulate” or “to collect.” The NLT

translates this simply as “They...will look for teachers....”

The people to whom Paul refers are those who will not want to listen to the true doctrine. Instead, they will choose to listen to many different religious teachers who will come to them with new, false ideas about Jesus or how to behave as a Christian. These false teachers will come at various times, not all at the same time, as the BSB may seem to imply.

4:3d

to suit their own desires.

- they can do the evil things that they want/desire to do.
- Instead of accepting sound doctrine and living according to it, they will follow their own evil desires,

to suit their own desires: The clause to suit their own desires means that people will choose to live very differently from the way that the word of God says that people should live.

Scholars have several views about the way the clause to suit their own desires is connected to the rest of the verse.

1. It contrasts with the implied information “people should accept and live according to sound doctrine” and is a coordinate statement with 4:3c. For example, GW says:

Instead, they will follow their own desires and surround themselves with teachers.... See also GNT, REB, NLT.

1. It modifies “teachers” in 4:3c. For example, the NCV says:

but will find many more teachers who please them.... See also CEV, JBP.

1. It indicates the reason why they will gather teachers, that is, “they will gather teachers in order to suit their own desires....” See BSB, NIV, RSV.

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1).

2 Timothy 4:4

Section 3:10–4:8: Paul gave Timothy some more instructions and encouraged him to continue preaching the gospel

In 3:10–4:8 Paul reminded Timothy that Timothy had thoroughly learned true doctrine, so he should con-

tinue to preach it faithfully, even if he had to suffer because of it.

4:4a

So they will turn their ears away from the truth

- People will turn their ears/attention away from the truth
- People will no longer want to listen to anyone who teaches the true word of God.

So they will turn their ears away from the truth:

Here Paul continued to use the image of the ear that he introduced in 4:3. The clause turn their ears away is a figure of speech in which a person’s ears represent his or her willingness to listen. It indicates that people will decide not to continue listening to those who teach the true understanding of the word of God.

4:4b

and turn aside to myths.

- and will turn them/it towards myths.
- Instead, they will listen to and believe untrue myths/legends.

and turn aside to myths: This clause means that these people will start listening to myths.

myths: The Greek words that Paul used here actually say the myths. This shows that Paul was referring to specific myths that Timothy already knew about. He probably meant the myths that he had warned Timothy about in 1 Timothy 1:4 and 1 Timothy 4:7. These may have been old legends that the people of Paul’s time told, or they may have been stories that the false teachers had invented. Whatever the source might have been for these legends, they were not true.

2 Timothy 4:5

Section 3:10–4:8: Paul gave Timothy some more instructions and encouraged him to continue preaching the gospel

In 3:10–4:8 Paul reminded Timothy that Timothy had thoroughly learned true doctrine, so he should continue to preach it faithfully, even if he had to suffer because of it.

4:5

This verse is a final summary of what Paul wanted to instruct Timothy to do in order to serve God as a minister of the gospel. 4:5 is all one sentence in the Greek text and also in the BSB, but it may be necessary for you to divide it into several sentences.

4:5a

But you, be sober in all things,

- But you, Timothy, you must keep control of yourself at all times,

But you: As in 3:10a and 3:14a, this verse begins with two Greek words that mean “but you (sing).” These words indicate a clear contrast between Timothy and the people of 4:3–4. If your language can make such strong contrasts, you should do so here. For example, you could say: “But as for you...”

be sober in all things: The Greek word that the BSB translates as be sober in all things is a figure of speech that means that Timothy is to keep control of himself.

This word closely follows Paul’s warning that people would reject the truth of the word of God. It may mean that Paul was reminding Timothy that he should be self-controlled regarding any new teaching that might sound believable but was untrue. Timothy was to think clearly and not believe such false teaching. However, Paul also uses this word in a more general sense, indicating that Timothy should be self-controlled in every aspect of his ministry.

in all things: Other ways to translate the phrase in all things would be “in all situations,” “at all times” or “whatever happens.”

4:5b

endure hardship,

- endure suffering,
- Be patient when you suffer.

endure hardship: This is a theme in this letter. Paul was certain that enduring suffering was a necessary part of life for anyone who serves the Lord. (See 3:12b.)

4:5c

do the work of an evangelist,

- preach the gospel to people who have not yet heard it,

do the work of an evangelist: In the places where Timothy was teaching non-Christians, he would need to evangelize them. In other words, he would have to tell them the good news that Jesus had been punished for their sins when he died and rose again.

evangelist: The Greek word that the BSB translates as evangelist is found only here and in Acts 21:8 and Ephesians 4:11. Literally it means “messenger of good (news).” See evangelist in the Glossary.

4:5d

fulfill your ministry.

- and perform/fulfill all your responsibilities.
- Do all the work that God gives you to do.

fulfill your ministry: The Greek word that the BSB translates as fulfill also means “to discharge” or “to perform.” In addition to Timothy’s responsibilities as an evangelist, he also had responsibilities as a teacher and preacher of the word of God. Paul had instructed him to direct or oversee what people said and taught when the believers gathered as a group to worship God. He was to be careful not to allow anyone to teach false doctrines, or to discuss or argue about unimportant details. Because of the way in which Paul instructed and commanded Timothy, we know that Paul was telling him to oversee all that happened in the church at Ephesus.

2 Timothy 4:6

Section 3:10–4:8: Paul gave Timothy some more instructions and encouraged him to continue preaching the gospel

In 3:10–4:8 Paul reminded Timothy that Timothy had thoroughly learned true doctrine, so he should continue to preach it faithfully, even if he had to suffer because of it.

4:6a

For I am already being poured out like a drink offering,

- ¶ I give you these commands because my life is like a drink offering that a priest pours out as a sacrifice. This means that
- ¶ I give you these commands, because my life and work for God are already ending;
- ¶ Just as the drink offering is poured out as the final part of the sacrifice, even so this is the final part of my life.

For I: In the same way that Paul used a pronoun and conjunction in 4:5a to highlight what Timothy was to do in contrast to the false teachers, so here he begins this thought in Greek with the pronoun meaning I and a conjunction. The pronoun emphasizes Paul’s situation compared to Timothy’s.

The Greek conjunction *gar*, “for,” indicates that 4:6 gives the reason why Paul had given Timothy the commands in 4:5. Timothy needed to “fulfill” his “ministry” because Paul would not be alive much longer to help him.

being poured out like a drink offering: The phrase being poured out like a drink offering is the BSB translation of one Greek verb. This verb is found only here and in Philippians 2:17. It literally means “being poured out” and describes one particular type or part of a Jewish sacrifice.

Exodus 29:38–41 describes the ritual for offering sacrifices to God each morning and evening. The sacrifice included a lamb, an offering of grain mixed with oil, and a specific quantity of wine, which a priest “poured out” or “poured over” the other things. The wine that the priest poured out was called the “drink offering.” It was the final part of the entire sacrifice.

In this verse, Paul used the word meaning “being poured out” in a figurative sense. Paul considered his entire life to be a sacrifice to God. This part of his life was the final part of that sacrifice, just as the drink offering was the final part of an animal sacrifice. In other words, Paul was saying that he would die soon.

When translating this phrase, you have several possibilities:

- Use the figure of speech, but add a phrase to “being poured out” so that the meaning will be easier to understand. The BSB and most other English versions do this. For example, CEV says:

My life is like a drink offering being poured out on the altar.

- Explain the figure of speech. You can say something like,

Just as the offering of wine is poured out at the end of the sacrifice, even so my life is at its end.

- Replace the figure of speech with the direct meaning. If you cannot retain the figure, you can say something like,

My life is already ending....

My life and work for God are ending....

4:6b

and the time of my departure is at hand.

- the time for me to leave this world is nearly here.
- I will die soon.

and the time of my departure is at hand: The phrase my departure is a euphemism for “my death.” Paul wrote these words to Timothy because the Romans had condemned him to die, and he knew that they planned to kill him soon.

General Comment on 4:6

In some languages it may be more natural to reorder 4:6a and 4:6b. For instance, you could say:

^{6b}I am about to die; ^{6a}my life is like a drink offering that is being poured out as a sacrifice.

2 Timothy 4:7

Section 3:10–4:8: Paul gave Timothy some more instructions and encouraged him to continue preaching the gospel

In 3:10–4:8 Paul reminded Timothy that Timothy had thoroughly learned true doctrine, so he should continue to preach it faithfully, even if he had to suffer because of it.

4:7

In this verse, Paul uses three vivid clauses to summarize all the events of his life and ministry as an apostle. These phrases emphasize Paul’s perseverance.

The clauses are short and parallel in form. This makes them easy to remember and recite. If it is possible in your language, use a similar structure in each of these clauses.

4:7a

I have fought the good fight,

- I have fought well in the contest.
- I have worked hard for Christ as if I have fought a fight of faith.

I have fought the good fight: Scholars have different opinions about the meaning of the Greek here.

1. It means a fight. For example, the BSB says:

I have fought the good fight. See NIV, RSV, NASB, KJV, GW, NLT, CEV, JBP, and NCV.

1. It means a race. For example, GNT says,

I have done my best in the race. See also REB.

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1).

fought...fight: The Greek words that the BSB translates as fought and fight may refer to either athletic contests such as wrestling and boxing or to warfare. But here it is more likely that Paul was using a figure of speech that describes a fight in an athletic contest.

the good fight: A “good fight” is a metaphor. Paul meant that even though he had faced many difficulties while serving God, nevertheless he had always served God as well as he knew how to serve him. He had worked as hard as he could work. He had never quit.

4:7b

I have finished the race,

- I have finished running the race,
- I have completed the work that Christ Jesus gave me to do.

I have finished the race: This is a second figure of speech from sports. I have finished the race refers to completing a job by being committed and continuing to do the job even when it becomes difficult. It does not refer to finishing a job because one is strong and skillful. Paul referred to the way he had persevered in serving other people and Christ himself, because the Lord Jesus had called him to do that. When Paul wrote this, he knew that soon he would not be able to serve Jesus in this world because the Romans had sentenced him to die.

4:7c

I have kept the faith.

- I have kept/preserved the gospel/faith.

I have kept the faith: In this clause, the faith means the basic teachings that Christians believe. See faith in the Glossary, Meaning 2.

The Greek verb that the BSB translated have kept has several meanings. Here it means, “to hold (something) firmly” or “to not lose (something).”

Part of Paul’s duty as an apostle was to make sure that the basic teachings of the faith were not “lost” or changed by the false teachers or other people who opposed the gospel. Throughout his ministry, Paul did not allow the true message to be changed to make it seem more acceptable to his hearers.

2 Timothy 4:8

Section 3:10–4:8: Paul gave Timothy some more instructions and encouraged him to continue preaching the gospel

In 3:10–4:8 Paul reminded Timothy that Timothy had thoroughly learned true doctrine, so he should continue to preach it faithfully, even if he had to suffer because of it.

4:8a

From now on there is laid up for me the crown of righteousness,

- Now a victory crown is waiting for me in heaven for living right.
- From now onwards, God is keeping a reward for me in heaven. This reward is a victory crown for me because I have pleased and obeyed him/God.

From now on there is laid up for me the crown of righteousness: Here Paul used another figure of speech from sports. During the time that Paul lived, an

athlete who won a fight or a race or any other sports event received a crown made of leaves as a prize. Paul lived a righteous life and had done everything that God had told him to do, so he anticipated that God would give him a prize in heaven. Paul described his prize as a crown that was already in heaven waiting for him to arrive.

From now on: The crown was already in heaven waiting for Paul when he wrote this letter to Timothy.

the crown of righteousness: The Greek word that is translated by the BSB as crown is the same word that is used in 2:5b–c. It refers to the crown of leaves given to a winning athlete, not to the crown a king wears. It may be better to translate it as “reward” or “prize” instead of crown if your readers would not know this meaning. For example, the GNT says,

And now there is waiting for me the victory prize....

Scholars have several opinions about the meaning of the phrase crown of righteousness. Two possibilities are:

1. It is the reward or prize for a person who is righteous. In other words, it is the reward for a person who lives to please and obey God and who lives a life that God considers right. For example, the CEV says:

a crown will be given to me for pleasing the Lord.

1. It is the symbol that God has accepted someone and he is right in God’s eyes. For example, GW says:

The prize that shows I have God’s approval See also GNT, NCV.

Most English versions translate the phrase crown of righteousness literally and the reader cannot tell which option the version followed. It is recommended that if possible, you also do not specify which option you are following. However, if you need to be specific, it is recommended that you follow option (1). In the context, the crown is a reward, which fits better with option (1). See righteousness in the Glossary, Meaning 1.

Some ways to translate this term are:

crown of victory for living right

victory prize for pleasing God

reward because I was righteous

4:8b

which the Lord, the righteous Judge,

- The Lord Christ who judges all people fairly/justly

the Lord: In this context Bible scholars agree that the Lord refers to Christ.

the righteous Judge: Christ is the righteous Judge. He always judges people justly and fairly. The righteous Judge would give Paul this prize because Paul had lived righteously. See also righteous in the Glossary, Meaning 2.

4:8c

will award to me on that day—

- will reward me with the crown on that day of judgment.
- will give this crown to me on the day/time when he judges us^(incl).

will award to me on that day: The phrase on that day refers to the time when Christ will return to the earth and will judge all people. A similar phrase, for that day occurs in 1:12d.

4:8d

and not only to me,

- The Lord will give a reward not only to me,
- And I am not the only person to whom he will give a reward.

4:8e

but to all who crave His appearing.

- but he will also reward everyone who very much wants/waits to see him return to earth.
- Everyone who yearns to see him return will also receive that reward.

4:8d-e

and not only to me, but to all who: This grammatical construction (not only me, but to all who...) is stronger than a simple coordination of two groups ("me and all who..."). These words emphasize that Paul was including other Christians.

all who crave His appearing: Christ will also give a crown of righteousness to everyone who desires to see him. The constant, hopeful anticipation of the time when Christ will return is one of the main characteristics that distinguishes genuine Christians from other people.

crave: The word which the BSB translates as crave means "desire."

His appearing: The term His appearing refers to the time when "Christ will return."

2 Timothy 4:9

Section 4:9–18: Paul asked Timothy to come to him soon

This section contains a variety of specific instructions that Paul gave Timothy in the hope that Timothy would be able to come to Rome soon and spend some time with him.

4:9

Make every effort to come to me quickly,

- ¶ Timothy, try hard to come to me as soon as you can.

Make every effort to come to me quickly: Make every effort is an English phrase that translates one Greek verb. It means "to work/try hard" or "to put the most effort that you can into doing something." This same verb occurs in 2:15a. Paul wanted Timothy to try to come from Ephesus to Rome as soon as possible, even if it was difficult for Timothy to do.

Paul then mentioned several reasons why he wanted Timothy to come to Rome soon:

1. Demas had deserted him (Paul) (4:10a);
2. Crescens and Titus each had traveled elsewhere to serve God (4:10b and 4:10c);
3. Luke was the only person that had remained in Rome to help Paul (4:11a).

2 Timothy 4:10

Section 4:9–18: Paul asked Timothy to come to him soon

This section contains a variety of specific instructions that Paul gave Timothy in the hope that Timothy would be able to come to Rome soon and spend some time with him.

4:10a

because Demas, in his love of this world, has deserted me and gone to Thessalonica.

- I say this because Demas has abandoned me and gone to Thessalonica, because he loves the things that are in this world.
- because Demas, who loves the ways of this world, has left me and gone to the town of Thessalonica.

because: The Greek word that the BSB translates as because indicates that Paul was about to give Timothy some reasons why he wanted him to come and

visit him. Another common English translation for this word is “for.”

Demas: Demas had been a fellow worker of Paul the first time that Paul had been in prison in Rome. (See Philemon 24 and Colossians 4:14.) Demas had been in Rome again during this second time Paul was in jail, but he had left without Paul’s approval.

in his love of this world: This means that Demas preferred to enjoy what he thought were the good things in this world. It also included the customs and practices that people did to please themselves at that time. Paul used the expression this world in 1 Timothy 6:17 with the same meaning.

Although Paul was disappointed that Demas abandoned him, he did not say that Demas was no longer a believer.

has deserted me and gone to Thessalonica: Thessalonica is the name of a town that was in the Roman province of Macedonia. Today that area is part of the country of Greece. Paul and Timothy had been there together in earlier times. (See Acts 16:3–17:15.)

4:10b

Crescens has gone to Galatia,

- Also, Crescens has gone to the province of Galatia,

Crescens has gone to Galatia: The second reason that Paul wanted Timothy to come to him was because Crescens had gone to Galatia. Your translation should also show this connection to 4:9. One way to do this is to say, “Also, Crescens....”

Crescens: Crescens is the name of a man who had been with Paul in Rome. Paul did not imply that Crescens (and Titus, 4:10c) had disobeyed him or abandoned him by leaving. He probably had sent him to preach the good news about Jesus Christ. He was just pointing out another reason why he needed Timothy.

No other passage in the New Testament mentions Crescens.

Galatia: Galatia was a Roman province located in the center of the area that is now the country of Turkey.

4:10c

and Titus to Dalmatia.

- and Titus has gone to the province of Dalmatia.

and Titus to Dalmatia: This statement is the third reason in Paul’s list.

The verb in this clause is missing in the BSB (and in the Greek) because the original readers would understand it to be the same verb as Paul used in 4:10a and 4:10b, that is, “has gone.”

Titus: Titus was a Greek man who believed in Christ. He was one of the men whom Paul trusted to help him to establish churches when Paul went on some of his missionary journeys.

Dalmatia: Dalmatia was the region that is now the country of Albania and included certain areas to the northwest of Albania. However, in your translation, it is sufficient to identify Dalmatia as a Roman province.

2 Timothy 4:11

Section 4:9–18: Paul asked Timothy to come to him soon

This section contains a variety of specific instructions that Paul gave Timothy in the hope that Timothy would be able to come to Rome soon and spend some time with him.

4:11a

Only Luke is with me.

- Luke alone has stayed with me.
- Luke is the only one who remains with me.

Only Luke is with me: This is another reason Paul asked Timothy to come to him. He did not have enough people to help him do all the work he wanted to do.

4:11b

Get Mark and bring him with you,

- When you come, get Mark and bring him with you,
- Contact Mark and bring him along with you,

Get Mark and bring him with you: Bible scholars are not sure where Mark was at this time. Apparently Timothy knew where he was. It also seems probable that Timothy would be able to go to the place where Mark was staying as he traveled on his way to Rome. The important point is that Paul wanted Timothy to contact Mark and to bring him to Rome.

4:11c

because he is useful to me in the ministry.

- because he will be able to help me in my work here.

because he is useful to me in the ministry: This clause gives the reason why Paul wanted Timothy to bring Mark with him.

in the ministry: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as in the ministry is literally “in service.” Paul probably meant that Mark could help him both in preaching and teaching the word of God Mark could also help Paul in personal and practical ways while Paul was a prisoner.

2 Timothy 4:12

Section 4:9–18: Paul asked Timothy to come to him soon

This section contains a variety of specific instructions that Paul gave Timothy in the hope that Timothy would be able to come to Rome soon and spend some time with him.

4:12

Tychicus, however, I have sent to Ephesus.

- I sent Tychicus to the town of Ephesus.

Tychicus...I have sent to Ephesus: Tychicus was another one of Paul's co-workers. He apparently had been in Rome before Paul told him to go to Ephesus. So Tychicus was yet another person who was no longer with Paul. This is a reason why Paul wanted Timothy to come and bring Mark along to help him.

2 Timothy 4:13

Section 4:9–18: Paul asked Timothy to come to him soon

This section contains a variety of specific instructions that Paul gave Timothy in the hope that Timothy would be able to come to Rome soon and spend some time with him.

4:13a

When you come, bring the cloak that I left with Carpus at Troas,

- When you come, bring the coat that I left in Troas at the house of Carpus.
- I left my outer garment in the town of Troas with Carpus. Bring it to me when you come here.

cloak: The word cloak refers to a garment that a person would wear to stay warm. Another word for cloak is "coat." In 4:21a Paul wrote about the season of cold weather arriving before long, so he had a real need for his warm clothing.

You have two main options in translating this word:

- Use your word for whatever type of outer garment people wear to stay warm.
- Use a descriptive phrase. For example, "outer garment used to keep warm."

I left with Carpus at Troas: Paul had left his cloak at the house of a man called Carpus. This man lived in the town of Troas, which was on the northwest coast of the Roman province of Mysia. Timothy had been in that town with Paul some years earlier during one of Paul's missionary journeys.

4:13b

and my scrolls, especially the parchments.

- Also bring my scrolls, especially the ones that are made of sheepskin/goatskin.
- Also bring my scrolls, especially the important ones.

and my scrolls, especially the parchments: The people of Paul's culture used scrolls the way that people use paper and books now. A scroll was long piece of papyrus, leather or parchment that people wound around a stick in order to occupy less space and make it easy to carry. Paul probably wrote each of his letters on a scroll.

People usually made scrolls from papyrus, a kind of thick paper made from papyrus reed. People also made scrolls from parchment. Parchment was made from animal skin, usually sheepskin or goatskin. Parchment lasted longer than papyrus, so it was more expensive.

especially the parchments: Because parchments lasted longer than other types of scrolls, people wrote the most important documents on parchments. That is why Paul especially wanted Timothy to bring the parchments.

In many languages, there will be no word for scrolls or parchments. If this is true in your language, you can use a descriptive phrase or use a modern equivalent. For example, the GNT uses the word "books" instead of scrolls.

Some ways to translate this verse part are:

Bring my scrolls/books, especially the important ones.

Bring my scrolls/books, especially the expensive ones.

2 Timothy 4:14

Section 4:9–18: Paul asked Timothy to come to him soon

This section contains a variety of specific instructions that Paul gave Timothy in the hope that Timothy would be able to come to Rome soon and spend some time with him.

4:14a

Alexander the coppersmith did great harm to me.

- ¶ Alexander, who makes things from metal, greatly hurt me in my work/ministry.

Alexander the coppersmith did great harm to me: Paul wanted to warn Timothy about a man whose name was Alexander. He had harmed Paul in some way. This is the only place he is mentioned, so scholars assume that he must have been someone from

Ephesus. Luke mentioned a man called Alexander in Acts 19:33–34, and Paul mentioned a man who had this same name in 1 Timothy 1:20. However it was probably a common name at that time. So this Alexander in 4:14 probably was not the same person as those other men named Alexander.

coppersmith: A coppersmith was someone who made things out of copper, iron, or other metals. The Greek word is literally “coppersmith.” However, coppersmiths at that time worked not only with copper but also with other metals, so metalworker is another way that this Greek word can be translated.

great harm to me: The harm that Alexander did to Paul was that he opposed Paul’s work. It does not refer to harming him physically. (See 4:15b.)

4:14b

The Lord will repay him according to his deeds.

- The Lord Jesus will punish him for the evil that he has done.

The Lord: The Lord in this context probably refers to Christ.

will repay him according to his deeds: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as repay also means “reward.” (See GNT.) Here, however, it has a negative sense meaning “to judge” or “to punish.”

2 Timothy 4:15

Section 4:9–18: Paul asked Timothy to come to him soon

This section contains a variety of specific instructions that Paul gave Timothy in the hope that Timothy would be able to come to Rome soon and spend some time with him.

4:15a

You too should beware of him,

- You too should watch out for him,

You too should beware of him: Paul said that Timothy should “be on guard against,” or “watch out” for Alexander the coppersmith. Alexander might try to prevent Timothy from working as he should work, even as he had tried to prevent Paul from working.

4:15b

for he has vigorously opposed our message.

- because he strongly opposed our^(excl) words/teaching.
- because he was strongly against what we^(excl) preached/taught about Christ.

for he has vigorously opposed our message: This clause gives the reason why Timothy should beware of him. Alexander had opposed the message about Christ that Paul and his companions had preached and taught. Since Timothy preached the same message as Paul, Alexander surely would oppose him also.

opposed: The word opposed means “to be against.” Paul used the same Greek word in 3:8.

2 Timothy 4:16

Section 4:9–18: Paul asked Timothy to come to him soon

This section contains a variety of specific instructions that Paul gave Timothy in the hope that Timothy would be able to come to Rome soon and spend some time with him.

4:16a

At my first defense,

- ¶ The first time I went to court to defend myself,
- ¶ The first time I had to stand before the judge here in Rome to answer those who accused me of having done wrong,

At my first defense: The phrase my first defense refers to a session of a Roman court in which a judge asked Paul some preliminary questions. Paul tried to prove that he was innocent of the things people had accused him of doing. During the first session, the judge did not decide definitely whether Paul was guilty or innocent, and so he ordered Paul to appear in court a second time.

If the people in your area do not completely understand expressions that refer to courts and trials, it may be necessary for you to translate the phrase At my first defense something like this: “the first time I had to stand in front of the judge and answer his questions....”

4:16b

no one stood with me,

- no one came to testify/speak in my favor.

no one stood with me: No one went with Paul to testify in his favor when the judge questioned him that first time.

The order of words in Greek indicates that Paul was emphasizing no one.

4:16c

but everyone deserted me.

- Instead, they all abandoned me.

but everyone deserted me: Paul used the strong Greek word of contrast, *alla*, to emphasize everyone in contrast to the “no one” in 4:16b. He had hoped that at least one of his friends would be at the court to defend him when the judge asked him questions, but they all had abandoned him.

4:16d

May it not be charged against them.

- May this act not be counted against them by God.
- I pray that God will forgive them for abandoning me.
- God, do not count this act against them.

May it not be charged against them: The Greek word that the BSB translates as charged against is a term used to describe a person calculating costs and debts. Here Paul used the term figuratively, in the sense that God keeps a record of people’s sins. Paul’s friends had abandoned him, but he prayed that God would not count or record this act against them as a sin.

2 Timothy 4:17

Section 4:9–18: Paul asked Timothy to come to him soon

This section contains a variety of specific instructions that Paul gave Timothy in the hope that Timothy would be able to come to Rome soon and spend some time with him.

4:17a

But the Lord stood by me and strengthened me,

- The Lord Jesus, however, stood beside me there to help me, and he gave me strength
- However, the Lord Jesus, helped me. It was as if he were standing beside me supporting/helping me.

But the Lord stood by me: In 4:16–17, Paul contrasted those who deserted him with the Lord, who had not deserted him. To express the contrast, you might be able to say,

The Lord, however, stood by me....

the Lord: The word Lord here probably refers to Christ.

stood by me: The words stood by me are a figure of speech that mean that Jesus stayed with him to help him. Use this figure of speech in your translation if people understand it. Or, your language may have an expression that describes a person who is not afraid to be the only one with you when the authorities accuse you of having done something wrong.

4:17b

so that through me the message would be fully proclaimed,

- in order that I might be able to completely state the message about Jesus Christ
- Because he gave me strength, I was able to tell/preach clearly the good news about Jesus Christ.

so that through me the message would be fully proclaimed:

The judge asked Paul what his enemies had accused him of doing. The judge’s questions gave Paul an opportunity to clearly tell the good news about Jesus Christ to the judge and to all the other people who were in the court on that day.

4:17c

and all the Gentiles would hear it.

- so that all those non-Jewish people who were present might hear it.
- There were many non-Jewish people present in the court, and they all heard the good news.

and all the Gentiles would hear it: There were people from many different nations in Rome, in addition to the Roman citizens. Some Jews were present. But most of the people there were Gentiles (that is, non-Jews). Therefore, when the judge gave Paul the opportunity to defend himself in the court of the Roman government, many non-Jews heard him preach the gospel.

4:17d

So I was delivered from the mouth of the lion.

- The result of that trial was as though Christ saved me just before a lion was about to kill me.
- The Lord saved/delivered me just before I was going to be killed for my faith.

So I was delivered from the mouth of the lion: The clause I was delivered from the mouth of the lion is a very dramatic metaphor which means:

I was delivered from death

Christ saved me from death.

This was a live figure of speech at the time when Paul wrote, because the Roman government sometimes punished people by forcing them to stand in an arena where lions could attack them and kill them.

This was Paul’s way of saying that the Roman judge did not condemn him to death. The Roman judge could have decided that Paul must die. But Christ rescued Paul from this very great danger by causing the judge to decide to let him live. Paul compared this to being in a place where a lion was going to attack him, and Christ rescued him immediately before the lion could attack him.

2 Timothy 4:18

Section 4:9–18: Paul asked Timothy to come to him soon

This section contains a variety of specific instructions that Paul gave Timothy in the hope that Timothy would be able to come to Rome soon and spend some time with him.

4:18a

And the Lord will rescue me

- The Lord Jesus will rescue/deliver me

And the Lord will rescue me: The Lord had rescued Paul in the past (4:17). Therefore, Paul was convinced that the Lord would deliver him in the future. However, since Paul fully expected to die soon (4:6), he believed that the Lord would deliver him in a spiritual sense, not a physical one. He was not saying that the Lord would protect him from persecution or other hard experiences.

the Lord: As in 4:17a, the word Lord here probably refers to Christ.

4:18b

from every evil action

- from every evil thing that wants to harm me,
- from every evil act/deed that anyone does to me to destroy me.

from every evil action: The term every evil action refers to all the evil deeds that Satan or evil people would do to Paul. They wanted him to become discouraged, lose his faith, or sin, and to stop preaching about Jesus Christ.

4:18c

and bring me safely into His heavenly kingdom.

- and he will bring me safely to his kingdom in heaven.
- He will take me safely to heaven where he reigns as king.

and bring me safely: The Greek verb that the BSB translated as bring me safely is literally “will save.” Only the RSV tries to translate this literally. It is recommended that you follow the model of the BSB and the majority of other English versions.

His heavenly kingdom: This term refers to heaven, where Christ is with God the Father and where Christ will rule over everyone who believes in him.

4:18d

To Him be the glory forever and ever. Amen.

- Let us praise and worship him/the Lord forever. Amen.

- He is the one we praise and worship forever. Amen.

To Him be the glory forever and ever. Amen: As Paul tells Timothy about all that God has already done, and all that he will do in watching over Paul’s life, he switches to praising the Lord. This phrase is also found in the last part of 1 Timothy 1:17.

Him: The pronoun Him refers to the Lord Jesus.

the glory: In this verse glory refers to the praise, honor, and worship that people give to Christ. See glory in the Glossary, Meaning 2.

Amen: The word Amen means “We (incl) agree with this” or “May it be this way!” “Amen” is borrowed from Hebrew. It is often used at the end of praises and prayers.

If people in your area say Amen at the end of prayers, or use another word or phrase that has this type of meaning, you should use the same word here.

2 Timothy 4:19

Section 4:19–22: Paul sent greetings to the believers in Ephesus

4:19a

Greet Prisca and Aquila,

- ¶ Greet Priscilla and Aquila for me.
- ¶ Tell Priscilla and her husband Aquila that I am thinking of them and desire good things to happen to them.

Greet Prisca and Aquila: Priscilla and Aquila were the names of a Christian woman and her husband who were friends of Paul. (See Acts 18:1–3.) Paul had mentioned them before in other letters. Apparently at the time Paul wrote this letter to Timothy in Ephesus, they were there, too.

Greet: Paul asked Timothy to tell Priscilla and Aquila that Paul was thinking about them and wished them well.

Prisca: The Greek word here for the woman’s name is literally “Prisca.” It refers to the same woman whose name is given as Priscilla in Acts 18:1–3.

1. Many modern versions translate it as Priscilla here also, to avoid confusion. (See NIV, GNT, NLT, NCV, CEV.)
2. Several versions translate it literally as “Prisca.” (See BSB, RSV, NJB, GW, NASB, NET, REB.)

It is recommended that you follow option (1) and translate it as Priscilla.

4:19b

as well as the household of Onesiphorus.

- Also greet the family of Onesiphorus for me.

the household of Onesiphorus: Onesiphorus is the name of a Christian man. He had proved that he was a faithful friend to Paul. Paul also asked Timothy to greet all those who lived in Onesiphorus' house.

2 Timothy 4:20

Section 4:19–22: Paul sent greetings to the believers in Ephesus

4:20a

Erastus has remained at Corinth,

- Erastus stayed in the city of Corinth,

Erastus has remained at Corinth: Erastus is the name of a Christian man whom Timothy knew. On one of Paul's missionary trips, Timothy and Erastus had been his companions (Acts 19:22).

4:20b

and Trophimus I left sick in Miletus.

- and I left Trophimus in the town of Miletus, because he was sick.

Trophimus I left sick in Miletus: Trophimus was probably the same person that Luke mentioned in Acts 21:29. In that verse, Luke said that Trophimus was with Paul in Jerusalem on Paul's last visit there. Trophimus' home was in Ephesus, so Timothy probably knew him.

Miletus: Miletus was a town on the coast of the Roman province of Asia. It was not far from Ephesus. Apparently Erastus and Trophimus had both been with Paul on a recent trip, and Trophimus had been with Paul until they arrived in Miletus.

2 Timothy 4:21

Section 4:19–22: Paul sent greetings to the believers in Ephesus

4:21a

Make every effort to come to me before winter.

- Try hard to travel here before the cold-weather/winter arrives.
- Make every effort to get here before the season when there are many storms.

Make every effort to come to me before winter: Make every effort is an English phrase that translates one Greek verb. It means "to work/try hard" or "to put the most effort into it that you can." This same verb is found in 2:15a and 4:9.

winter: Timothy would have had to travel from Ephesus to Rome by sea. In winter, a trip across the sea in a ship was dangerous because of storms. If Timothy did not travel to Rome soon after he received Paul's letter, he might have to wait another five or six months until there was good sailing weather again.

If there is no cold season in your area, you could translate winter as "the time when there are many storms."

4:21b

Eubulus sends you greetings, as do Pudens, Linus, Claudia,

- Eubulus greets you, and Pudens, Linus, and Claudia also greet you.

Eubulus sends you greetings, as do Pudens, Linus,

Claudia: The people that Paul named in this list were in Rome and knew that Paul was sending a letter to Timothy. They each wanted Timothy to know that they were thinking about him and desiring that all would be well with him. Claudia was a woman. The other three were men.

4:21c

and all the brothers.

- All the brothers and sisters here also send their greetings to you.
- All the other believers here send you their greetings too.

all the brothers: The word brothers here means "the believers" and probably includes both men and women. In your translation, you can say "all the other believers" or "all the brothers and sisters."

2 Timothy 4:22

Section 4:19–22: Paul sent greetings to the believers in Ephesus

Paragraph 4:22

Paul ended his letter to Timothy with a short blessing.

4:22a

The Lord be with your spirit.

- ¶ May the Lord be with you.
- ¶ May the Lord Jesus Christ bless you, Timothy.

The Lord: The Lord here refers to the Lord Jesus.

be with your spirit: Another way to say be with your spirit is "be with you" or "bless you." In Greek, your spirit is in the singular, and this shows that Paul addressed this to Timothy.

4:22b

Grace be with you all.

- May God bless you.^(plur)
- May God show favor to all of you.^(plur)

Grace be with you all: Paul frequently ended his letters with these same words, or very similar words. (See Galatians 6:18; Philippians 4:23; Colossians 4:18 and 1 Timothy 6:21.)

Grace: As Paul did in 1:2c, here he was using Grace as a Christian blessing. It refers to God being kind and favorable toward people. Therefore avoid using a long phrase to describe grace in this context. See grace in the Glossary, Meaning 1.

you all: Paul blessed Timothy personally in 4:22a. Here in 4:22b, he blessed both Timothy and the other believers at Ephesus.

General Comment on 4:22b

These words are a wish or a prayer. In some languages it may be necessary to begin this prayer with the words “I ask...” or “I pray...,” for example:

I pray that God will...be kind to you (CEV).

I ask God to bless you.

If there is a word or phrase in your language for “bless” that means “to do good things for another person,” this may be appropriate here. If you use “bless” in your translation of this verse, you should be certain that it means: “May God help you (plur) and do good things for you (plur).”